A DISSERTATION

The Red Slayer and the Unified Field

CONTAINMENT, FISSION, AND THE NOCTURNAL TRANSCENDENTALISM OF DAVID LYNCH

OCTOBER 2026



Abstract

This dissertation advances a unified theory of the work of David Lynch (1946–2025) across cinema, television, painting, sound, and the meditative writings. It argues that the oeuvre constitutes a single, internally coherent cosmology, which I term *Nocturnal Transcendentalism*. Existing scholarship has divided into three camps. Psychoanalytic accounts address fantasy and desire (Mulvey, Žižek, McGowan). Spiritualist and Gnostic accounts address transcendence (Nochimson, Wilson). Historicist readings (Jameson, Nieland) occupy a third and largely separate position. I propose that these are partial descriptions of one dynamic structure organized by three terms: the *Field*, the *Fission*, and the *Containment*.

The Field designates the Vedantic ground of pure consciousness that Lynch encountered through Transcendental Meditation in 1973. He theorized it as the reservoir from which ideas, figured as fish, are caught. Its American genealogy runs through Emerson's Over-Soul and his *Gītā*-derived poem "Brahma," whose "red slayer" names the figure this study pursues into the Red Room. The Fission designates the splitting of that ground. It was enacted literally at the Trinity test of 16 July 1945, which Part 8 of *Twin Peaks: The Return* stages as the theogony of BOB. It is enacted figuratively in the doppelgänger, the bifurcated narrative, and the daughter divided within the father's house. The Containment designates the regime that conceals and stores the energy released by fission. David Foster Wallace defined the Lynchian as the macabre's "perpetual containment" within the mundane. Read alongside George Kennan's geopolitical doctrine and Elaine Tyler May's "domestic containment," that definition makes the white picket fence legible as the shielding wall of a reactor.

Across seven chapters the dissertation reconstructs two genealogies. The genealogy of the Field runs through the Upaniṣads, Schopenhauer, Emerson, Maharishi Mahesh Yogi, Robert Henri, and Jung's *unus mundus*. The genealogy of the Fission runs through Hoffmann, Poe, Stevenson, Dostoevsky, Freud, Rank, Kafka, Bacon, Buñuel, Deren, Cocteau, and Lacan. The dissertation then proposes a political economy of *garmonbozia*, linking the Lodge's consumption of human suffering to Gnostic archontology, to the Eleusinian revelation of an ear of grain reaped in silence, and to the extractive economies of timber and Hollywood. It maps Lynch's late narrative architecture onto the four states of consciousness of the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*. It reads *The Return* as a failed Grail quest in which Dale Cooper, an Orphic Perceval, poses a chronological question where the Grail demands a compassionate one.

Against Lovecraftian indifference, Machen's lifted veil, and Ligotti's puppet pessimism, the dissertation concludes that Lynch's soteriology is non-narrative. Redemption does not arrive through retroactive intervention in a fissioned history. It arrives through stillness, slowness, and attention: *The Straight Story*, the angel of *Fire Walk with Me*, and the sourceless voice of Club Silencio. Drawing on Chion's acousmatics and the yogic doctrine of *anāhata nāda*, this study identifies that voice as the unstruck sound of the Field itself. The resulting concept of the *fissile sublime* names the signature Lynchian experience: the perception of unity available only at the instant of its rupture.

Contents

—	Abstract	02
I	INTRODUCTION The Ear in the Grass	04
1	CHAPTER ONE The Field *Upaniṣad, Over-Soul, and the Metaphysics of the Big Fish*	14
2	CHAPTER TWO The Split *The Uncanny, the Double, and the European Genealogy of the Lynchian*	26
3	CHAPTER THREE Trinity *Fission, Electricity, and the Atomic Theogony of Part 8*	37
4	CHAPTER FOUR Garmonbozia *Affective Extraction, Eleusis, and the Woman in Trouble*	49
5	CHAPTER FIVE The Fissioned Self *Fugues, Tulpas, and the Four States of Consciousness*	61
6	CHAPTER SIX The Grail Question *Orpheus, Perceval, and the Failure of Retroactive Redemption*	72
7	CHAPTER SEVEN The Straight Path *Silence, Slowness, and the Soteriology of the Field*	81
C	CONCLUSION The Fissile Sublime	91
—	Works Cited	98
—	Keywords	102

EVIDENTIARY KEY

D Documented genealogy H Structural homology C Constellational disclosure

INTRODUCTION

I

The Ear in the Grass

The path to the Field now runs not through Emerson's daylight woods but through a red room at night.

§ I.4

I.1 The Primal Scene of a Cosmology
I.2 The Problem of the Lynchian
I.3 The Moving Painting
I.4 Field, Fission, Containment
I.5 Method: Piscatorial Hermeneutics
I.6 Plan of the Argument

I.1

The Primal Scene of a Cosmology

The first minutes of *Blue Velvet* (1986) compress the Lynchian cosmos into a single descending movement. Red roses nod against a white picket fence beneath an untroubled sky. A fire engine glides past in slow motion, a fireman waving from its side with the beatific fixity of a figure on a devotional card. Schoolchildren cross beneath a crossing guard's raised palm. The images are not naturalistic but hypersaturated, an advertisement for a world rather than a world. Fredric Jameson found in such images the postmodern "nostalgia mode" at work, in which a lacquered simulacrum of the 1950s displaces historical time.

Then the sequence breaks. Tom Beaumont, watering his lawn, finds his hose snagged. He clutches his neck and collapses in a stroke while the jet, released from its governing hand, sprays upward and a small dog snaps at the water. The camera does not attend to the fallen father. It descends past him into the grass, and beneath the grass, into a roaring subterranean world of black beetles locked in mandibular combat. Their sound is amplified into a rumble more geological than entomological.

Every term of the argument this dissertation develops is present here in compressed form.

- **Containment.** The fence, the roses, and the slow-motion wave form a surface whose excessive brightness is the signature of the labor required to maintain it.
- **Fission.** The snagged hose and the stroke interrupt a current: water in the hose, blood in the patriarch's brain. The obstruction does not halt the flow but converts it into convulsion.
- **Field.** The descent passes vertically beneath the surface toward a substratum that the catastrophe did not create but merely disclosed. That substratum is, decisively, sonic before it is visual.

The father struck down in his own garden is the paradigmatic Lynchian Fisher King, whose wound lays waste the land and summons the questing son.

What the son finds is an ear. Returning from his father's hospital bed across a vacant lot, Jeffrey Beaumont discovers a severed human ear in the grass, crawling with ants. The camera then performs the film's governing gesture. It advances into the ear canal until the screen goes black, and the entire nocturnal narrative of Lumberton unfolds as though within that aperture: Dorothy Vallens, Frank Booth, the Deep River Apartments. In the final sequence the camera reverses the movement and withdraws from Jeffrey's own ear into daylight. The diegesis is thus framed, quite literally, as an event within the organ of hearing.

Two genealogies converge on this image. The first is surrealist. In Buñuel and Dalí's *Un Chien Andalou* (1929), ants swarm from a wounded palm, in a film inaugurated by a razor drawn across an eye. Lynch relocates surrealism's founding assault on vision to the ear, announcing a cinema governed by the acoustic rather than the optic.

The second genealogy is American and Transcendentalist. In *Nature* (1836), Emerson describes the ecstatic dissolution of the self in the woods: "I become a transparent eyeball; I am nothing; I see all; the currents of the Universal Being circulate through me." Lynch's ear is the exact negative of Emerson's eye: opaque rather than transparent, severed rather than dilated, infested rather than illuminated. Yet, like that eye, it is a portal through which the self passes into an impersonal order. The passage from transparent eyeball to severed ear, from the Concord noon to the Lumberton night, from the circulation of currents to their electrical hum, is the passage from Transcendentalism to what this study calls Nocturnal Transcendentalism.

A last detail will recur. The slow-motion fireman of 1986 returns thirty-one years later as the Fireman of *The Return*, the cosmic agent who answers the atomic birth of evil by sending Laura Palmer into the world. Under the method set out below, this is not a coincidence to be explained away but a rhyme to be read.

I . 2

The Problem of the Lynchian

The adjective "Lynchian" entered critical and then common usage with unusual speed. Its canonical gloss remains David Foster Wallace's 1996 report from the set of *Lost Highway*. Wallace defined the term as a species of irony in which the very macabre and the very mundane combine so as to reveal the former's "perpetual containment" within the latter. The definition has been cited so often that its most consequential word has gone unread.

In the American vocabulary of the late twentieth century, "containment" was never a neutral spatial metaphor. It carried three meanings at once.

- **Geopolitical.** It was the master term of Cold War strategy, formulated in George Kennan's Long Telegram of February 1946 and his "X" article of July 1947.
- **Domestic.** Elaine Tyler May, in *Homeward Bound* (1988), identified "domestic containment" as the Cold War's internal corollary. In that ideology the sexually regulated nuclear family served as a bulwark against both communism and atomic dread.
- **Nuclear.** In nuclear engineering, containment is the shell of steel and concrete that surrounds a reactor so that the energy of fission may be harnessed without escaping.

Read in this triple sense, Wallace's definition already contains the present thesis. The Lynchian is the aesthetic of a containment culture. Its suburban surfaces are shielding walls, behind which the energy of a split is stored and through whose fissures it leaks.

Mark Fisher's late taxonomy in *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) refines the phenomenology. For Fisher, the weird is constituted by the presence of what does not belong. The eerie is constituted by a failure of absence or of presence: something where there should be nothing, or nothing where there should be something. Lynch's distinction is to occupy both registers at once and to modulate between them with a sound engineer's precision.

The Man from Another Place, dancing in a red room and speaking in reversed speech, is weird in Fisher's strict sense. The darkened corridors of the Madison house in *Lost Highway* are eerie. So is the room tone that persists beneath Lynchian scenes like the hum of an unlocated transformer. In the terms developed here, these are the two perceptible forms of fission. The weird is the fragment that has broken off and appears where it should not. The eerie is the vacancy the fragment leaves behind.

The scholarship has divided along a line this dissertation proposes to close.

Psychoanalytic readings form one pole:

- Laura Mulvey's "Netherworlds and the Unconscious" (1996) reads *Blue Velvet* as an Oedipal descent in which the son discovers the father's obscene double.
- Slavoj Žižek's *The Art of the Ridiculous Sublime* (2000) finds in Lynch's monstrous fathers, Frank Booth and Mr. Eddy, an obscene jouissance of the superego that is at once terrifying and ludicrous.
- Todd McGowan's *The Impossible David Lynch* (2007) argues that the films separate the world of desire from the world of fantasy, often into distinct narrative halves, in order to stage their traumatic collision.

Spiritualist and Gnostic readings form the other pole:

- Martha Nochimson's *The Passion of David Lynch* (1997) and *David Lynch Swerves* (2013) describe a cinema of intuitive receptivity opposed to logocentric narrative control.
- Eric G. Wilson's *The Strange World of David Lynch* (2007) reads the films through Gnostic cosmology and Romantic irony.

Formal and historical studies stand between them:

- Michel Chion's monograph (1992; English translation 1995) is still the most acute on Lynch's sonic textures.
- Justus Nieland's *David Lynch* (2012) addresses plastics, interiors, and an ambivalent modernism.

- Allister Mactaggart's *The Film Paintings of David Lynch* (2010) and Dennis Lim's *The Man from Another Place* (2015) extend the formal and biographical account.
- Jameson's *Postmodernism* (1991) treats even the film's transgressions as simulacra.

None of these accounts is mistaken; each covers only one sector. The psychoanalytic readings offer an exact phenomenology of the Fission: the subject split between desire and fantasy, the father split into law and obscenity. The spiritualist readings describe the Field toward which Lynch's statements and practice point. The historicist readings describe the Containment.

What is missing is an account of how the three form a single dynamic system. Also missing is an explanation of why that system found its fullest expression in this particular artist. Lynch was born six months after the first atomic detonation. He spent half a century meditating twice daily on a Vedic model of consciousness. Throughout that time he made films about the pathogens of the American home.

I . 3

The Moving Painting

Lynch's cinema began, by his own account, as a disturbance in a painting. As a student at the Pennsylvania Academy of the Fine Arts, he was working on a nocturnal canvas of a garden, green forms emerging from a field of black. He then perceived the plants move and heard a wind. The desire that followed was for a painting that would move and sound. It produced *Six Men Getting Sick* (1967): a looped animation of six figures vomiting, projected onto a sculpted screen to the accompaniment of a siren.

The anecdote is usually told as a parable about crossing from one medium to another. It is better read as a parable of ontology. A static ground, black and undifferentiated, is disturbed by a wind with no visible source, and the disturbance yields figures that convulse and expel. The Field is the dark ground of the canvas. The Fission is the convulsion of the figures. The Containment is the frame and the loop that hold the convulsion in endless repetition. The siren, sound as alarm, announces that this art will not merely depict catastrophe but monitor it.

The formation preceding this moment requires only summary. Lynch's father, Donald Lynch, was a research scientist for the U.S. Department of Agriculture. The family moved through Missoula, Sandpoint, Spokane, Durham, Boise, and Alexandria, which gave the child an intimate acquaintance with forests, small towns, and the scientific study of what lives beneath bark. Lynch often recalled a cherry tree oozing dark pitch and swarming with red ants. That memory supplies the elemental image of the later work: a viscous darkness seeping from within a living surface and colonized by insects.

Several further influences shaped him:

- **Robert Henri.** Through the painter Bushnell Keeler, the father of a friend, Lynch encountered Henri's *The Art Spirit* (1923). He adopted its doctrine of the art life, disciplined attention lived as a total way of being, as a creed.
- **Oskar Kokoschka.** A 1965 journey to study with Kokoschka in Salzburg collapsed within roughly a fortnight. The failure returned Lynch to an American subject.
- **Philadelphia.** Lynch lived there in the late 1960s amid industrial ruin, violence, and decay, and consistently named the city his greatest influence. Its corrosion would condense into the wasteland of *Eraserhead* (1977).
- **Francis Bacon.** Among painters, Bacon held a singular place for Lynch. Bacon painted isolated figures within spatial armatures, flesh rendered as meat, and mouths opened on a scream whose cause lies outside the frame.

Bacon told David Sylvester that he had wanted to paint the scream more than the horror. Gilles Deleuze's *Francis Bacon: The Logic of Sensation* (1981) generalized the point through Paul Klee's formula: art does not reproduce the visible but renders visible. The painter's task, on this view, is to make perceptible forces that are not themselves visible. This furnishes the first axiom of the present study. Lynch's images are the visible effects of invisible forces, and those forces are the currents of a Field undergoing fission.

I.4

Field, Fission, Containment

This dissertation argues that the Lynchian corpus constitutes a single cosmology. The corpus here includes the student films, *Eraserhead*, *The Elephant Man*, *Dune*, *Blue Velvet*, *Twin Peaks* and *Fire Walk with Me*, *Wild at Heart*, *Lost Highway*, *The Straight Story*, *Mulholland Drive*, *Inland Empire*, and *Twin Peaks: The Return*, together with the paintings, sound works, and meditative writings. The cosmology can be stated in five propositions.

> **First, reality is grounded in a unified field of consciousness.** This is not a metaphysics imposed upon Lynch but his own repeatedly stated position. It derives from Transcendental Meditation, which he began practicing in 1973, and from the Advaita Vedānta that Maharishi Mahesh Yogi systematized for Western audiences. In *Catching the Big Fish* (2006), Lynch describes ideas as fish swimming at varying depths of this field, the largest and most beautiful at the greatest depth.

The doctrine has an American genealogy a century older than TM. Emerson's Over-Soul was nourished on English translations of the Upaniṣads and the *Bhagavad Gītā*. His poem "Brahma" (1857) opens with the line "If the red slayer think he slays." The line renders the *Gītā*'s teaching (2.19) that neither the one who thinks he slays nor the one who thinks himself slain knows the truth, since the Self neither slays nor is slain. Slayer and slain seated together in a red room is, I shall argue, the central tableau of *Twin Peaks*.

> **Second, evil is the parasitic yield of fission.** Lynchian evil is not a substance coeval with the good, as in Manichaean dualism. Nor is it simply the good's privation, as in Augustine. It is the energy released when the One is split, and its agents feed upon that energy: BOB, the Woodsmen, the Mystery Man, Frank Booth. *Fire Walk with Me* names this food *garmonbozia*, pain and sorrow, materialized as creamed corn.

Fission takes three privileged forms in Lynch:

- **Historical.** Part 8 of *The Return* stages the Trinity test, scored to Krzysztof Penderecki's *Threnody to the Victims of Hiroshima* (1960), as the theogony of BOB.
- **Psychological.** The doppelgänger.
- **Domestic.** The daughter divided within the father's house.

> **Third, postwar American normality is a containment structure.** The suburb, the small town, the diner, the sitcom, and the Hollywood dream factory are shielding walls. Their function is to store fissile energy while concealing its existence. The brightness of Lynch's surfaces is the visible effort required to hold them in place.

> **Fourth, the characteristic Lynchian affect is what I term the *fissile sublime*: the perception of the unified field available only at the instant of its rupture.** Earlier theories located the sublime elsewhere:

- Burke located it in terror apprehended at a safe distance.
- Kant located it in the imagination's failure before a magnitude or a might that reason nonetheless thinks.
- Rudolf Otto located it in the *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* of the numinous.

The fissile sublime differs from each, because in it totality is disclosed not by magnitude but by division. Matter revealed its energy only in being split. Likewise, the *Gītā*'s theophany appears to Arjuna on a battlefield, as the radiance of a thousand suns, in the verse Oppenheimer is reported to have recalled at Trinity. The fissile sublime has a comic double, which Žižek calls the ridiculous sublime, and it follows from the same mechanism. Fission produces doubles, and doubling, as Bergson argued in *Le Rire*

(1900), is the elementary form of the comic: *du mécanique plaqué sur du vivant*, the mechanical encrusted on the living.

> **Fifth, Lynch's soteriology is non-narrative.** Narrative intervention in a fissioned history does not restore unity but splits the world again. The hero who returns to undo the original wound only deepens it. Dale Cooper's attempt to rescue Laura Palmer from her death demonstrates this by producing a further and darker split. Redemption, where it occurs, is achieved through stillness, slowness, and attention:

- the meditative tempo of *The Straight Story*;
- the angel who appears to Laura only after her death;
- the luminance in which *Eraserhead* dissolves;
- the voice that continues in Club Silencio after the singer has collapsed, which Chapter Seven identifies with the *anāhata nāda*, the unstruck sound of yogic tradition.

I name this position Nocturnal Transcendentalism. It is Transcendentalist in its fidelity to the Emersonian and Vedantic conviction that individual consciousness opens onto a universal one, and that this opening is benevolent at its ground. Lynch's public insistence on bliss, unity, and the eventual triumph of light is the authentic expression of that conviction rather than its ironic mask. It is nocturnal in that it receives this conviction after Trinity. In this epoch the ground of matter has been opened by violence, and the currents of the Universal Being have become the hum of the electrical grid. The path to the Field now runs not through Emerson's daylight woods but through a red room at night.

I . 5

Method: Piscatorial Hermeneutics

Lynch's refusal to explain his work poses a methodological problem for any study that proposes to interpret it. He consistently declined to gloss his images. He maintained that a film's meaning is complete in the experience of it and that verbal explanation diminishes it. This dissertation does not treat that refusal as an obstacle, nor override it in the name of interpretive authority. It reads the refusal as a theory of meaning, one that licenses the method adopted here.

Suppose ideas are not authored but caught, arriving from a field that precedes and exceeds individual consciousness. Then intention is not the origin of a work's meaning but only one point of contact with a larger reservoir. Lynch's position radicalizes, at the level of metaphysics, the anti-intentionalism that W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley

codified in "The Intentional Fallacy." That essay was published in 1946, a coincidence this study will learn to read rather than dismiss. It follows that the critic may fish in the field from which the work was drawn. The critic may legitimately land correspondences the artist never consciously baited.

I call this method piscatorial hermeneutics. It has two emblems:

- **A comic emblem.** In the pilot of *Twin Peaks*, Pete Martell is alarmed to find a fish in the percolator. The depths have intruded into the domestic apparatus whose whole function is filtration.
- **A tragic emblem.** The Fisher King of the Grail romances is a wounded fisherman whose healing depends upon a question rightly asked.

Piscatorial hermeneutics is not free association. Its procedure is the constellation as Walter Benjamin defined it in the epistemo-critical prologue to *The Origin of German Tragic Drama* (1928). Ideas are to phenomena as constellations are to stars. A constellation does not reduce the stars to a concept; it arranges them so that a figure becomes legible. To discipline this method, every claim in the dissertation is advanced at one of three levels of evidentiary force.

- **Documented genealogy** D**.** These claims rest on Lynch's statements, verifiable biography, or demonstrable citation. Examples are his practice of TM, his reading of Henri, his reverence for Bacon and Kafka, and the explicit intertexts of *The Wizard of Oz* in *Wild at Heart* and *Sunset Boulevard* in *Mulholland Drive*.
- **Structural homology** H**.** These claims assert that Lynch's forms share a structure with a philosophical, mythological, or literary model, without asserting influence. The correspondence between the four states of consciousness in the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* and the architecture of *Mulholland Drive* is of this kind.
- **Constellational disclosure** C**.** These are the boldest claims and are offered as such. They are justified by their yield, that is, by whether they make visible something in the work that would otherwise remain unseen. One example is a convergence of three Lynchian images: *Blue Velvet*'s severed ear, the creamed corn of the Lodge, and the silence of Club Silencio. All three converge on the Eleusinian revelation reported by Hippolytus of Rome: an ear of grain reaped in silence.

The argument's strength does not depend on any single constellation. It depends on the convergence of all three levels upon one structure.

I.6

Plan of the Argument

- **Chapter One** reconstructs the genealogy of the Field. It runs from the Upaniṣadic identity of Ātman and Brahman through Schopenhauer's veil of Māyā and Emerson's Over-Soul. It continues through Maharishi's Science of Creative Intelligence and its fusion with unified-field physics, Henri's art spirit, and Jung's *unus mundus*. The chapter argues that Lynch's red curtain is a theatrical rendering of Māyā, and that his refusal of explanation is an apophatic pedagogy.
- **Chapter Two** reconstructs the counter-genealogy of the Split. It begins with Hoffmann's "The Sandman" and Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919). It continues through Rank, Poe, Stevenson, Dostoevsky, and Kafka, and ends with Buñuel, Maya Deren, and Cocteau.
- **Chapter Three** reads Part 8 of *The Return* as an atomic theogony. It situates that episode within the constellation of 1945–47: Trinity, the Long Telegram, Lynch's own birth, and the occult and UFO ferment of those years that Mark Frost folds into the town's prehistory. It theorizes Lynchian electricity as the fallen form of the Emersonian current.
- **Chapter Four** develops the political economy of garmonbozia. Its comparisons include Gnostic archontology, Robert Monroe's "loosh," Castaneda's "flyers," the fear-eating entity of Stephen King's *It*, and the extractive economies of timber and Hollywood. It situates the "woman in trouble" within the feminist controversy that has shadowed Lynch's reception since Roger Ebert's condemnation of *Blue Velvet*.
- **Chapter Five** treats the fissioned self: the psychogenic fugue of *Lost Highway*, the dream-economy of *Mulholland Drive*, and the tulpas of *The Return*, which have their source in Alexandra David-Néel. It maps the late narratives onto the *Māṇḍūkya*'s four states, comparing them with Zhuangzi, Calderón, Carroll's Red King, and Borges's "The Circular Ruins."
- **Chapter Six** reads *The Return* as a failed Grail quest and a failed Orphic descent. Its sources include Chrétien, Wolfram, Jessie Weston, Cocteau's *Orphée*, the Demeter–Persephone cycle, and Benjamin's angel of history.
- **Chapter Seven** turns to the counter-tradition within Lynch's own work: *The Elephant Man*, *The Straight Story*, the endings of *Eraserhead* and *Fire Walk with Me*, and Club Silencio. It sets this counter-tradition against Lovecraft's cosmic indifference, Machen's *The Great God Pan*, and Thomas Ligotti's puppet pessimism.
- **The Conclusion** formalizes the fissile sublime and proposes Nocturnal Transcendentalism as a category that reaches beyond Lynch himself.

CHAPTER ONE

1

The Field

UPANIṢAD, OVER-SOUL, AND THE METAPHYSICS OF THE BIG FISH

The American pond and the Indian river share one water, and Lynch fishes in that water at night.

§ 1.5

1.1 The Piscatorial Doctrine
1.2 Śruti: The Ocean, the Fish, and the Ear of the Ear
1.3 Māyā, Superimposition, and the Twilight Snake
1.4 Schopenhauer's Torn Veil: Tormentor and Tormented
1.5 Concord at Night: Emerson, Thoreau, Whitman
1.6 Maharishi and the Physics of Consciousness
1.7 The Art Spirit: Henri, Hopper, and the State Prior to the Work
1.8 Unus Mundus: Jung, Pauli, and the Epistemology of Synchronicity
1.9 The Red Curtain and the Yavanikā
1.10 Apophatic Pedagogy and the Torus

1.1

The Piscatorial Doctrine

Lynch's aesthetic theory is unusually explicit for an artist so committed to refusing explanation, and its locus is a single book. *Catching the Big Fish: Meditation, Consciousness, and Creativity* (2006) is written in brief, aphoristic chapters. Its informality has led critics to treat it as an inspirational supplement to the films. This chapter reverses that judgment and treats the book as the films' metaphysical ground. The book's governing figure, ideas as fish and consciousness as water, is not decorative. It sets out a complete theory of creative causation, and that theory has four parts.

- **Ontology.** Beneath the agitated surface of ordinary thought lies an ocean of pure consciousness, unbounded and unified, which Lynch, following the Transcendental Meditation movement, calls the unified field.
- **Epistemology.** Ideas are received rather than produced. They swim at varying depths, the small near the surface and the large and beautiful far below, so the quality of a catch depends on the depth at which one fishes.
- **Psychology.** Desire functions as bait. An idea arrives first as a fragment, and the fragment, once held, draws further fragments toward it until a work assembles itself.
- **Ethics.** Negativity (anger, depression, fear) does not deepen art but constricts it. Lynch's image for it is a suffocating rubber clown suit, a costume that binds the living body in a mechanical shell D. He rejects the Romantic doctrine that the artist must suffer to depict suffering: one needs to understand pain to render it, not to be in it, and understanding flows more freely from bliss.

The ethical claim generates the central paradox this dissertation names Nocturnal Transcendentalism. Consider the most harrowing images in late-twentieth-century American cinema: the mutant infant of *Eraserhead*, Frank Booth's assault on Dorothy Vallens, the murder of Laura Palmer, the figure behind Winkie's diner. On their maker's account, all of them were caught by a fisherman who had meditated twice daily since 1973 and who described the ground of his consciousness as bliss.

The paradox resolves only under two conditions. The Field must contain the full range of possible forms, the darkest included, rather than being a neutral ground. And the meditator's equanimity must be what lets him descend to the depths where those forms swim without being destroyed by them. Lynch's clown-suit image is the hinge. Negativity, on his account, is the mechanical encrusted upon the living, which is the very formula Bergson gave for the comic. The rubber suit that suffocates the artist is also the costume of the ridiculous sublime. It is the grotesque surface of fission that the films display and that the meditator, unlike his characters, need not wear.

1.2

Śruti: The Ocean, the Fish, and the Ear of the Ear

The Field Lynch describes has a precise Upaniṣadic shape (H, with D for its transmission through TM). In the sixth chapter of the *Chāndogya Upaniṣad*, Uddālaka Āruṇi instructs his son Śvetaketu through a series of demonstrations that culminate in the refrain *tat tvam asi*, "that thou art." Rivers flowing east and west enter the ocean and become the ocean, and there they no longer know themselves as this river or that (6.10). Salt dissolved overnight in water cannot be seen or grasped, yet it is tasted in every sip (6.13). The *Muṇḍaka* (3.2.8) generalizes the figure: as rivers entering the sea give up name and form (*nāma-rūpa*), the knower, freed from name and form, enters the supreme person.

Lynch's ocean of consciousness is a modern rendering of this Upaniṣadic hydrology. In it, individual ideas swim before being drawn up into the differentiated world of names and forms. His description of its quality as bliss corresponds to the Vedāntic definition of Brahman as *saccidānanda*, being-consciousness-bliss.

Two further Upaniṣadic structures bear directly on the films. The first is the *Kena Upaniṣad*'s description of Brahman as "the ear of the ear, the mind of the mind, the speech of speech, the breath of breath, the eye of the eye" (1.2). On this account the ultimate ground is not an object of the senses but the hearing within hearing: that by which the ear hears, and which the ear itself cannot hear.

Read through this verse, the governing gesture of *Blue Velvet* acquires a metaphysical precision that neither the surrealist nor the Emersonian genealogy supplies C. The camera advances into a severed ear until the screen goes black; it is seeking the ear of the ear. What it finds there is not Brahman but Lumberton's underworld. In a fissioned cosmos, the path to the hearing within hearing passes through everything the Field has been made to contain.

The second structure concerns authorship. The Vedas are *śruti*, "that which is heard." They are revelation received by the ṛṣis, seers who did not compose the hymns but heard them. The Mīmāṃsā school accordingly held the Vedas to be *apauruṣeya*, not of human origin. Lynch's model of the idea that is caught rather than invented is a modern instance of this model of authorship H. It grounds the anti-intentionalist method of this study in a tradition far older than Wimsatt and Beardsley.

The model's mythological emblem is Matsya, the fish. In the earliest version of the Indian flood narrative (*Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* 1.8.1), a small fish found in Manu's washing water asks for protection. It grows enormous, warns Manu of the coming deluge, and tows his ship to safety. In the Purāṇic elaborations, Matsya becomes the first avatar of Viṣṇu. He slays the demon Hayagrīva, who has stolen the Vedas from the sleeping Brahmā, and restores them to the world (*Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 8.24). The big fish of Indian

myth is literally the bearer of revealed knowledge out of the depths of the flood. Lynch's piscatorial doctrine thus recapitulates, almost certainly without intending to, the oldest Indian myth of how knowledge survives catastrophe C.

The *Taittirīya Upaniṣad* adds a final structure that later chapters will need. Its doctrine of the five sheaths (*kośa*) arranges the self in layers. The outermost is the sheath of food (*annamaya*); then come breath, mind, and understanding; the innermost is the sheath of bliss (*ānandamaya*). Its third chapter declares that beings are born from food, live by food, and return to food. Chapter Four will argue that the Lodge's hunger for garmonbozia demonically inverts this order. The Lodge entities feed at the outermost sheath on the pain that the innermost sheath, rightly approached, would dissolve.

1.3

Māyā, Superimposition, and the Twilight Snake

If the Field is one, the world of multiplicity requires explanation, and Advaita Vedānta's explanation is *māyā*. In the introduction to his commentary on the *Brahmasūtras*, Śaṅkara (c. eighth century) defines the fundamental error as *adhyāsa*, superimposition. Superimposition attributes the properties of one thing to another, paradigmatically the properties of the not-self to the self. Śaṅkara's canonical illustration is the rope mistaken for a snake in dim light. The snake is not nothing: it produces real fear and a real racing of the heart. But it has no being of its own. It is the rope misperceived, and it vanishes not when it is fought but when it is seen.

Three features of the illustration are Lynchian H.

- **Twilight.** The error occurs neither in full darkness, where nothing is seen, nor in daylight, where the rope is evident. It belongs to the liminal hour in which Lynch's films characteristically dwell.
- **Disproportion.** The error produces affect out of proportion to its object, which is the formal signature of Lynchian dread: terror at a man behind a diner wall, or at a ceiling fan turning in an empty stairwell.
- **Correction by perception.** The error is corrected by seeing rather than by action. This anticipates the fifth proposition of this dissertation, that Lynch's soteriology is non-narrative.

In this register, the Giant's warning to Cooper that the owls are not what they seem is a formula of māyā C. It declares that the perceptual world is a superimposition whose true referent lies elsewhere.

Yet *Twin Peaks* complicates Śaṅkara at a decisive point: in Lynch, the snake bites. The superimposed forms acquire agency and appetite. BOB is not simply the rope misper-

ceived but a misperception that has learned to feed. To understand how illusion becomes predatory, one must follow Vedānta into its European reception.

1.4

Schopenhauer's Torn Veil: Tormentor and Tormented

The Upaniṣads entered European philosophy through Abraham Hyacinthe Anquetil-Duperron's *Oupnek'hat* (1801–1802), a Latin rendering of a seventeenth-century Persian translation. Their most consequential reader was Arthur Schopenhauer, who declared the work the consolation of his life and of his death. In *The World as Will and Representation* (1818/1819), Schopenhauer takes over the figure of the veil of Māyā to name the *principium individuationis*. These are the forms of space, time, and causality through which a single underlying reality appears as many separate beings.

But Schopenhauer's underlying reality is not *saccidānanda*. It is the Will: blind, insatiable, and perpetually striving. Its nature condemns it to feed upon itself, since every individuated being sustains itself at the expense of others.

The decisive passage for this dissertation is §63 of Book IV, on eternal justice. Because the veil of Māyā divides the one Will into apparently separate individuals, each party misreads its situation. The tormentor believes he does not share the torment; the tormented believes he does not share the guilt. Seen through the veil, both are deceived. Tormentor and tormented are one, and the Will that inflicts suffering in one appearance endures it in another. In §§66–68, Schopenhauer derives his ethics of compassion (*Mitleid*) from this insight and grounds it explicitly in the Upaniṣadic *tat tvam asi*. The structure is identical to that of Emerson's "Brahma" and of the *Gītā*'s teaching on slayer and slain. What differs is how the ground is valued.

Here the European reception of Vedānta splits into two lines, and Lynch inherits both H C. In Emerson the ground is benevolent: the Over-Soul, the eternal One, a source of light. In Schopenhauer the ground is ravenous: a Will whose every manifestation is hunger.

The cosmology of *Twin Peaks* encodes this division in its two Lodges. The terms themselves are documented borrowings from Theosophical and post-Theosophical occultism, the province of Mark Frost's contribution to the series D. In that tradition a White Lodge of benevolent adepts descends from Helena Blavatsky's teaching, and Dion Fortune's *Psychic Self-Defence* (1930) describes Black Lodges of malign occultists. What the borrowing conceals is a philosophical structure:

- The White Lodge is the Field as Emerson received it.
- The Black Lodge is the Field as Schopenhauer received it.

- BOB, who devours garmonbozia, is the Schopenhauerian Will personified, the single appetite that consumes its own appearances.

Schopenhauer's ethics of compassion will return in Chapter Six through Wagner's *Parsifal* (1882). Its Grail knight is the pure fool made wise through compassion, and his most unexpected descendant is Dougie Jones.

1.5

Concord at Night: Emerson, Thoreau, Whitman

The American line begins with Emerson, and its founding texts already use the vocabulary this dissertation has proposed. "The Over-Soul" (1841) opens its central argument by diagnosing the condition the doctrine is meant to heal: "We live in succession, in division, in parts, in particles. Meantime within man is the soul of the whole; the wise silence; the universal beauty, to which every part and particle is equally related; the eternal ONE."

A century before Trinity, the passage names both poles of Lynch's cosmos. On one side stand division, parts, and particles: the language of fission. On the other stands "the wise silence," which is, across a century and a half, the name of Club Silencio C. Emerson's "Brahma" (1857), with its red slayer, carries the *Gītā* directly into American verse. Emerson had read Charles Wilkins's 1785 English translation. The poem baffled its first readers in the *Atlantic Monthly*, and that bafflement registers how strange nondual thought sounded in the American vernacular D.

The more exact ancestor of Nocturnal Transcendentalism, however, is Thoreau. In the *Walden* (1854) chapter called "The Ponds," Thoreau recalls fishing from a boat on Walden Pond at night. In the dark his thoughts would drift to vast and cosmogonal themes, until a faint jerk on the line interrupted his dreams and linked him to nature again. He imagined he might next cast his line upward into the air as well as downward into the water: "Thus I caught two fishes as it were with one hook."

This is the founding scene of the doctrine Lynch would set out a century and a half later H C. The setting is nocturnal, and the fisherman is dreaming of cosmogony. His line descends into a dark medium scarcely denser than thought, and the fish caught below is at the same time a thought caught above.

Elsewhere in *Walden*, in "The Pond in Winter," Thoreau describes bathing his intellect each morning in the "stupendous and cosmogonal philosophy of the Bhagvat Geeta." He imagines the ice cut from Walden mingling, in the holds of ships bound for India, with the sacred water of the Ganges. The circuit is complete: the American pond and the Indian river share one water, and Lynch fishes in that water at night.

Whitman supplies two further terms. The first is containment in its most expansive American form. The speaker of "Song of Myself" declares that he is large and contains multitudes, and that he therefore contradicts himself without anxiety. The American transcendental self is a vessel capacious enough to hold its contradictions without splitting. Lynch's protagonists are such vessels under pressure. Cooper contains Mr. C and Dougie, but the containment has failed, and the multitudes walk the earth separately.

The second term is technological transcendence. In "Passage to India" (1871), Whitman celebrates the Suez Canal, the transcontinental railroad, and the transatlantic cable as instruments of a spiritual unification of the globe. Spanned and connected by networks, the earth becomes the body through which the soul's passage is accomplished. Here the Emersonian current first becomes literally electrical, and the telegraph wire becomes a conduit of the Over-Soul. Chapter Three will argue that Lynch's humming power lines are the nocturnal inheritance of Whitman's cable. They are the same network, now carrying not the soul's passage to India but BOB's passage between bodies.

1.6

Maharishi and the Physics of Consciousness

The Vedānta that reached Lynch came not through Emerson or Schopenhauer but through Maharishi Mahesh Yogi (1918–2008) D. Maharishi was a disciple of Swami Brahmānanda Sarasvatī, Śaṅkarācārya of Jyotir Maṭh, and he carried that teaching to the West from the late 1950s. His distinctive contribution was to reframe Advaita as a technology and a science. He presented Transcendental Meditation not as a devotional discipline requiring renunciation but as an effortless technique. Using a mantra, the mind settles to progressively quieter levels of thought until it transcends thought altogether and experiences its own source.

In *Science of Being and Art of Living* (1963), Maharishi illustrates the process with an image that Lynch's fish adapts almost exactly. A thought arises like a bubble from the bottom of the ocean of mind and grows as it rises, until it is perceived at the surface. Meditation reverses the movement, following the thought down to the depths it came from. Maharishi's Science of Creative Intelligence, systematized in the early 1970s, called this source the field of pure creative intelligence, the reservoir from which all creativity is drawn. It was institutionalized in Maharishi International University, which relocated to Fairfield, Iowa, in 1974. This is the institutional origin of Lynch's claim that creativity depends on consciousness rather than on suffering or technique.

The decisive move for this dissertation was the identification of that field with the unified field of physics. The physicist John Hagelin, the TM movement's most promi-

nent scientist, argued in "Is Consciousness the Unified Field? A Field Theorist's Perspective" (1987) that the two are identical. On his account, the unified field sought by grand unified and superstring theories is the field of pure consciousness experienced in transcendence.

Mainstream physics has not accepted this identification. It conflates a mathematical structure describing the unification of fundamental forces with a phenomenological description of subjective experience. The movement's related claims about the collective social effects of group meditation likewise remain highly contested within mainstream science. For the present argument, though, the identification's validity matters less than its consequences within Lynch's imagination, which consistently speaks of the unified field in both registers at once D.

Those consequences are momentous. If the field of physics is the field of consciousness, then physical events are events in consciousness, and manipulating matter at its foundations is an operation on mind. Electricity is not a metaphor for spiritual current; it is spiritual current. The splitting of the atomic nucleus at Trinity is then not an image of spiritual catastrophe but a spiritual catastrophe. It is a wound inflicted on the Field itself, at the level where matter and consciousness are one.

This is the logical hinge on which Part 8 of *The Return* turns. It explains why that episode, among the most abstract hours ever broadcast on American television, is also among the most metaphysically coherent. Lynch did not need to invent a mythology linking the bomb to the birth of evil, because the physics of consciousness he had accepted since the 1970s already entailed it. The David Lynch Foundation for Consciousness-Based Education and World Peace, established in 2005, is the practical corollary of the same logic: if the Field can be wounded collectively, it can be healed collectively.

1.7

The Art Spirit: Henri, Hopper, and the State Prior to the Work

Before TM gave Lynch a metaphysics of the Field, Robert Henri gave him its aesthetic precursor D. *The Art Spirit* (1923), compiled by Margery Ryerson from Henri's teaching, holds that the artist's state of being precedes and determines the work. The purpose of the artistic life is therefore not the production of objects but the cultivation of that state: "The object isn't to make art, it's to be in that wonderful state which makes art inevitable."

This is already the TM doctrine in a secular key: the work is a byproduct of a condition of consciousness, and the artist's discipline is the discipline of reaching that condition. In adolescence Lynch adopted Bushnell Keeler's "art life" of coffee, cigarettes, and

uninterrupted painting. In doing so he adopted Henri's priority of state over product, and his later turn to meditation completed that priority rather than replacing it.

Henri's teaching also places Lynch in a precise American lineage H. Henri's students at the New York School of Art included Edward Hopper. Hopper's paintings of stilled figures in diners, offices, theaters, and hotel rooms form the visual archive of the American containment interior. *Nighthawks* (1942) shows a diner glowing on a dark corner with no visible door. It is the iconographic ancestor of the Double R Diner and of Winkie's in *Mulholland Drive*: the all-night counter as a lit capsule of ordinary life suspended in darkness, its occupants enclosed, waiting, and silent. Henri's art spirit and Hopper's night meet in Lynch, who brings the first's doctrine of the luminous state to the second's vision of the enclosed and waiting American.

1.8

Unus Mundus: Jung, Pauli, and the Epistemology of Synchronicity

The closest Western analogue to the unified field of consciousness is Carl Gustav Jung's *unus mundus*. Jung took the term from the sixteenth-century alchemist Gerhard Dorn and developed it in *Mysterium Coniunctionis* (1955–1956) to designate the unitary reality in which psyche and matter are not yet differentiated. He worked out a related idea with the physicist Wolfgang Pauli. Their joint volume *Naturerklärung und Psyche* (1952), which included Jung's essay "Synchronicity: An Acausal Connecting Principle," proposed that meaningful coincidences between inner states and outer events reveal a "psychoid" level of reality beneath the distinction of mind and matter. The Jung–Pauli dialogue anticipates Hagelin's identification with greater caution and theoretical sophistication. It also supplies something TM does not: an epistemology.

Twin Peaks is the most sustained dramatization of synchronistic epistemology in American popular culture H. The second episode is titled, tellingly, "Zen, or the Skill to Catch a Killer." In it, Cooper presents to the sheriff's department a method of investigation that came to him in a dream about the people of Tibet. As each suspect's name is read aloud, he throws a stone at a bottle and treats the hits and misses as evidence. His dream of the Red Room at the episode's close supplies the clues on which the investigation will turn.

Cooper's detection rests on the premise that the inner world of dream and the outer world of evidence are aspects of a single order. Intuition, on this premise, is not a supplement to deduction but its foundation. This is the Jungian *unus mundus* turned into procedure. Its comic presentation, with the deputies bemused and the stones scattering, belongs to the ridiculous sublime that fission generates.

Jung also supplies the Nocturnal Transcendentalist's governing maxim. In his alchemical studies he insisted that one becomes enlightened not by imagining figures of light but by making the darkness conscious. He warned repeatedly that Western practitioners who adopt Eastern methods to escape the shadow will find it returning in projected and monstrous form. Lynch, the meditator who descends into the darkest material of American life, is the artist of this maxim. His films do not substitute figures of light for darkness. They render the darkness visible from a position of equanimity, the only position from which it can be made conscious without being enacted.

1.9

The Red Curtain and the Yavanikā

The single most recurrent image in Lynch's work is the curtain.

- The opening credits of *Blue Velvet* play over a rippling expanse of blue velvet, and Dorothy Vallens performs on the stage of the Slow Club.
- Red drapes line the corridors of the Madison house in *Lost Highway*.
- Red curtains enclose the Red Room in *Twin Peaks*, *Fire Walk with Me*, and *The Return*.
- At Club Silencio in *Mulholland Drive*, a master of ceremonies appears before the curtain to announce that there is no band.
- In Part 8 of *The Return*, the Fireman watches the atomic birth of evil on a screen in a vast theatrical hall.

The curtain in Lynch is never merely décor. It marks the boundary between the visible world and what produces it, and it is the theatrical form of the veil of Māyā H.

The identification has a philological dimension that rewards attention C. In classical Sanskrit drama the stage curtain was called the *yavanikā*. Nineteenth-century Indologists, notably Ernst Windisch in 1882, connected the word to *Yavana*, the Sanskrit term for Greeks, as evidence of Hellenistic influence on Indian theater. The etymology remains contested, but it places the curtain at the meeting point of two traditions that converge in Lynch.

- **The Indian tradition** supplies the veil of Māyā, which conceals the One behind the many.
- **The Greek tradition** supplies a Pythagorean legend: the master taught his novices, the *akousmatikoi*, from behind a curtain, so that they heard his voice without seeing its source. From this legend Pierre Schaeffer derived the term *acousmatic*. Michel Chion, Lynch's most attentive critic, built on it a theory of the cinematic voice whose source is withheld.

The Lynchian curtain therefore conceals both the One (Māyā) and the speaker (the acousmatic). Chapter Seven will argue that at Club Silencio these two concealments are revealed to be one. The voice continues after the singer falls because its source was never the singer but the Field.

The chevron floor of the Red Room belongs to the same complex C. Its zigzag is the sign of the waveform, of alternating current, of lightning: the visible notation of a current oscillating between poles. The curtain conceals the source, and the floor inscribes the current that flows from it.

1.10

Apophatic Pedagogy and the Torus

The Introduction presented Lynch's refusal to explain as a methodological problem. It can now be identified as a pedagogy with a long theological lineage H.

- The *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* describes the self only by negation, *neti neti*, "not this, not this" (2.3.6), because every positive predicate would make it an object among objects.
- Pseudo-Dionysius, in the *Mystical Theology*, directs the soul beyond both affirmation and negation into a brilliant darkness of hidden silence.
- The Zen kōan disables discursive reason in order to bring on an insight that reasoning cannot produce.

Lynch's films act on the spectator in the same way. Withholding explanation forces the viewer to abandon the search for a decodable meaning and to dwell in the experience itself. In TM's terms, this is the movement from the active surface of the mind toward its settled ground.

The most explicit document of this pedagogy is the insert that accompanied the home-video release of *Mulholland Drive*. It offered ten "clues" that resolve nothing. Most are directives to notice something, such as a red lampshade or the location of an accident; the rest are questions left unanswered. A clue that is a question is a kōan.

Lynch's personal motto completes the theology. He frequently cited a slogan he associated with the Mayflower doughnut shops: keep your eye upon the doughnut and not upon the hole. Read as a statement of metaphysical orientation, the motto directs attention to plenitude rather than lack, to the Field rather than the void C. In this sense it is an anti-Lacanian creed. Lacanian psychoanalysis constitutes the subject around a lack. Lynch's Lacanian critics, Žižek and McGowan foremost among them, keep their eye precisely on the hole: the traumatic void around which desire and fantasy circulate. Yet Lacan himself, in his ninth seminar (*Identification*, 1961–1962), adopted the torus,

the mathematical doughnut, as a topological model of the subject. In that model the central void is encircled by the loops of demand and desire.

The coincidence resolves the scholarly divide that the Introduction identified. Topologically, the doughnut and its hole are not two things but one surface. The hole is not an absence opposed to the dough. It is a feature that constitutes the form, and without it there is no torus at all. The spiritualist critic who sees the dough and the psychoanalytic critic who sees the hole are describing the same object from complementary positions.

Lynch's cosmology is toroidal in exactly this sense. The Field is the plenitude, Fission opens the void, and the two are aspects of a single surface on which every Lynchian narrative travels. The next chapter takes as its subject the hole: the void opened in the Field.

CHAPTER TWO

2

The Split

THE UNCANNY, THE DOUBLE, AND THE EUROPEAN GENEALOGY OF THE LYNCHIAN

Lynch's cosmology adds that when the self divides, the world divides with it.

§ 2.7

2.1 From Illusion to Wound
2.2 What Ought to Have Remained Hidden: Hoffmann, Jentsch, Freud
2.3 The Insurance Against Death: Rank, Poe, Dostoevsky, Stevenson
2.4 Bodies Under Sentence: Kafka and the Elephant Man
2.5 Mirrors, Keys, and Radios: Buñuel, Deren, Cocteau
2.6 The Barred Subject: Lacan's Mirror and the Obscene Father
2.7 The Lynchian Difference: From Psychology to Cosmology

2.1

From Illusion to Wound

Chapter One closed on the hole: the void that opens in the Field and around which, topologically, the Field takes its form. This chapter traces how European thought came to understand that void, and here the difference from the Indian tradition is decisive.

For Advaita Vedānta, multiplicity is *māyā*, a superimposition that dissolves when it is seen. The split is an error of perception, and knowledge corrects it. For the European line that runs from Romantic fiction through psychoanalysis, the split is a wound. Seeing it does not dissolve it; seeing it is itself traumatic. The division constitutes the subject rather than deceiving it. Freud's late paper on the splitting of the ego in the process of defense (1938) names the mechanism. Lacan generalizes it into a structural principle, writing the subject as barred, divided by its entry into language. Between these two poles lies a century of fiction in which the self is split by eyes, machines, mirrors, chemicals, and insects.

Lynch inherits this line as fully as he inherits Vedānta. The originality of his cosmology lies in refusing to choose between them. His splits are both illusory and real: illusory because the Field remains one beneath them, real because they bleed, feed, and walk. The European tradition supplies the phenomenology of fission, the precise texture of what it feels like when unity breaks. The Indian tradition supplies the ontology of the unity that breaks.

This chapter reconstructs the European phenomenology as five modes of splitting, each with founding texts and a Lynchian afterlife:

- the split of perception (Hoffmann, Jentsch, Freud);
- the split of the self (Rank, Poe, Dostoevsky, Stevenson);
- the split of the body (Kafka, Bacon, the medical gaze);
- the split of the world (Buñuel, Deren, Cocteau);
- the split of the subject (Lacan).

A final section identifies what Lynch adds to all five.

2.2

What Ought to Have Remained Hidden: Hoffmann, Jentsch, Freud

E. T. A. Hoffmann published "The Sandman" (1816) in a volume he called *Nachtstücke*, "night pieces." The generic title matters: the founding text of the modern uncanny is

formally a nocturne D. A primal scene organizes its plot.

As a child, Nathanael hides to watch his father and the lawyer Coppelius at their secret nocturnal work over a hearth. Coppelius discovers the boy and threatens to take his eyes. A year later, during another night's experiment, an explosion kills the father, and Coppelius vanishes. The adult Nathanael believes he recognizes Coppelius in the itinerant optician Coppola and buys a spyglass from him. Through it he falls in love with Olympia, daughter of Professor Spalanzani, who turns out to be an automaton whose eyes Coppola supplied. Nathanael's madness culminates on a tower: seeing Coppelius through the glass, he plunges to his death.

The constellation with Part 8 of *The Return* is precise enough to state as such C:

- In Hoffmann, a nocturnal experiment by the father and a sinister double ends in an explosion. The explosion begins the son's lifelong persecution by a figure who returns in successive disguises.
- In Lynch, the nocturnal experiment at Trinity ends in an explosion. From it, an entity credited simply as "Experiment" vomits forth BOB, who will return across decades in successive hosts.

The alchemical hearth has become the atomic test site, but the structure is unchanged: an experiment of the fathers releases a persecutor who will afflict the children.

Two readings of "The Sandman" founded the theory of the uncanny, and Lynch's work requires both. Ernst Jentsch, in "On the Psychology of the Uncanny" (1906), located the effect in intellectual uncertainty. Its exemplary case is doubt about whether an apparently living being is animate, or whether a lifeless object might be alive, and Jentsch took Olympia as his example. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) rejected this emphasis. Freud located the effect in the threatened eyes, which he read as displaced castration anxiety, and more generally in the return of what has been repressed. He also showed philologically that *heimlich* (homely, familiar) develops toward an ambivalence until it coincides with its opposite, *unheimlich*. That demonstration made the uncanny a function of the home.

Most consequential for this dissertation is the definition Freud quotes from Schelling: the uncanny is everything that ought to have remained secret and hidden but has come to light. Schelling's definition describes a containment breach H. The uncanny is not the strange but the formerly contained, and its affect is proportional to the effort the containment required. Every Lynchian house is a Freudian *Heim* in this sense. Heidegger's account of anxiety in *Being and Time* (§40), in which the everyday world suddenly discloses itself as not-at-home (*Unheimlichkeit*), describes the phenomenology of Lynch's interiors. Examples include the Palmer staircase beneath its turning fan, the Madison corridors, and the Beaumont kitchen to which Jeffrey returns from the underworld.

Jentsch's automaton is equally indispensable, because Lynch's cinema is crowded with figures whose animation is uncertain:

- Laura Palmer's corpse, discovered on the shore wrapped in plastic like a doll in its packaging;
- the mechanical robin that closes *Blue Velvet* with an insect in its beak;
- the human-sized rabbits of *Rabbits* (2002), delivering disconnected lines to a canned laugh track that arrives at the wrong moments;
- most extensively, Dougie Jones, the doll-like residue of Dale Cooper, who repeats the last words spoken to him and moves through *The Return* like a marionette whose strings are held elsewhere.

Freud's uncanny attaches to what returns; Jentsch's attaches to what is ambiguously alive. Lynch's characteristic acting style, with its flattened affect, mannered line readings, and unexpected pauses, extends Jentsch's uncertainty to the entire human cast H. Bergson's "mechanical encrusted on the living" reappears here not only as comedy but as dread. The oscillation between the two is the ridiculous sublime.

Freud's castration reading supplies the psychoanalytic grammar of *Blue Velvet*'s ear. In Freud's logic, the threatened eye stands in for the threatened genital. In Lynch's film, Frank Booth has severed the ear of Dorothy's husband, holds husband and son hostage, and extorts Dorothy's sexual submission. Laura Mulvey's Oedipal reading follows. The severed ear is the mark of a paternal castration inflicted by an obscene father on a captive one. Jeffrey, watching Frank and Dorothy through the slats of the closet, occupies the position of the child at the primal scene. The organ has shifted from eye to ear, and with it the medium of trauma has shifted from vision to sound. The camera that passes into the ear is entering, among other things, the wound.

2.3 The Insurance Against Death: Rank, Poe, Dostoevsky, Stevenson

Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914 in *Imago*; expanded 1925) is the first systematic psychoanalytic study of the double. Significantly, it begins with a film: Stellan Rye and Hanns Heinz Ewers's *The Student of Prague* (1913). In it, an impoverished student sells his mirror reflection to a sorcerer, and the reflection steps out of the glass to commit crimes in his name (D for Rank's use of the film). Rank's thesis, which Freud adopted, holds that the double originates as an insurance against death, a guarantee of the soul's survival. Once that primitive narcissism is surmounted, the double becomes the uncanny harbinger of death.

The reflection that leaves the mirror is the founding cinematic image of the doppelgänger, and its descendants fill Lynch's work. Leland Palmer sees BOB's face in his reflection before he kills Maddy. In the closing shot of the second season, Dale Cooper, returned from the Lodge, smashes his head against a bathroom mirror, and the glass shows BOB's laughing face where his own should be. The double that escapes the mirror in *The Student of Prague* becomes, a century later, the double that escapes the Lodge in *The Return*.

The literary genealogy divides the double's functions among three canonical texts:

- **Conscience (Poe).** In "William Wilson" (1839), a namesake shadows the dissolute narrator and frustrates each act of vice. The narrator finally stabs him and hears, in the dying double's voice, that he has murdered himself.
- **Social rival (Dostoevsky).** In *The Double* (1846), the clerk Golyadkin is supplanted by an identical, ingratiating Golyadkin Junior who succeeds everywhere he fails, until the original is led away to the asylum.
- **Chemical extract (Stevenson).** In *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886), a drug separates an unmixed evil from the mixed nature of a respectable man. Jekyll's final statement concludes that man is not truly one but truly two, and perhaps a polity of many incongruous denizens.

Lynch's films reassemble these functions into new configurations H. *Lost Highway* follows Dostoevsky's structure. A jealous, apparently impotent husband is replaced, inexplicably and physically, by a younger man whose sexual success with the double of his wife completes the fantasy the husband could not realize. *Mulholland Drive* follows Poe's. Diane arranges the murder of the woman who is both her beloved and her mirror, and the murder returns upon her as self-destruction: her suicide completes the self-murder that Poe's narrator discovers too late.

The Return follows Stevenson's, with a decisive asymmetry. Jekyll observes that Hyde, at first smaller and less developed than his respectable self, grows stronger with every release. Lynch's split Cooper obeys the same law. Mr. C is vigorous, criminal, and sovereign over his territory, while the good remainder, Dougie, is diminished almost to infancy. Fission in Lynch does not divide a mixed nature into equal halves of good and evil. It produces a concentrated evil and an emptied good, and the residue of goodness is not a lesser hero but a holy fool.

Two further texts complete the European archive. Hoffmann's *The Devil's Elixirs* (1815–1816) binds the double to a hereditary curse. The monk Medardus, shadowed by his double Viktorin, discovers that his crimes reenact a sin committed generations earlier in his ancestral line. *Twin Peaks* adopts this genealogical structure when it reveals that BOB first entered Leland Palmer in childhood. The father's crime against the daughter thus repeats a violation once inflicted upon the father H.

Gogol's "The Nose" (1836) supplies the comic ancestor of the autonomous organ C. In it, a functionary's nose detaches itself and moves through Petersburg in the uniform of a higher rank. *Blue Velvet*'s ear is Gogol's nose in a tragic register: a part of the body that has separated from its owner and become the bearer of its own story.

The American Gothic offers a pendant. In Hawthorne's "Young Goodman Brown" (1835), a Puritan villager walks into the forest at night and finds the town's deacons, matrons, and minister gathered at a witches' sabbath, the respectable community revealed as a coven. The story is the template for the topography of *Twin Peaks* H. The woods around a decent logging town conceal a roadhouse, a brothel across the Canadian border, and a lodge of spirits. The town's leading citizens, a hotel magnate and a beloved lawyer among them, turn out to lead double lives. Hawthorne's forest is the first American Black Lodge.

2.4

Bodies Under Sentence: Kafka and the Elephant Man

Of all his predecessors, Kafka is the one Lynch named with the greatest intimacy: he described him as the single artist he could imagine as a brother. Lynch wrote, but never produced, an adaptation of *The Metamorphosis* D.

The kinship pervades *Eraserhead* (1977). Henry Spencer inhabits a Kafkaesque room in a Kafkaesque city. He is summoned to a nightmarish dinner with his girlfriend's family, where her father invites him to carve tiny "man-made" chickens that writhe and bleed under the knife. He is then presented with a malformed infant he is told he has fathered. *Eraserhead* inverts *The Metamorphosis*: Kafka's family must host the insect their son has become, whereas Lynch's son must host the creature his paternity has produced. In both cases the monstrous body is a judgment on the family, and in both the judgment ends in death. Gregor dies with his father's apple rotting in his back. Henry stabs the infant with scissors, and the world dissolves.

Kafka's other fables of judgment supply further structures H:

- **"In the Penal Colony" (written 1914, published 1919).** An apparatus inscribes the condemned man's sentence on his body with needles until, in the sixth hour, he deciphers it through his wounds. BOB places a small printed letter beneath each victim's fingernail, which makes the body a page in the same sense: each corpse bears a fragment of an inscription that only the series of bodies can complete.
- **"Before the Law" (1915).** A man from the country waits his whole life before a door meant for him alone, until the doorkeeper closes it. Cooper's twenty-five years in the Lodge's waiting room are a vigil before a door of exactly this kind.

- **Scholem's formula.** In his 1934 correspondence with Walter Benjamin, Gershom Scholem described the law in Kafka as possessing validity without significance (*Geltung ohne Bedeutung*). This is the most precise available description of the Lodge's utterances. "The owls are not what they seem" and "That gum you like is going to come back in style" are statements with absolute force and no determinate content: laws that bind without meaning.

The Kafkaesque in Lynch also has a comic register. Kafka earned his living in insurance, as an official of the Workers' Accident Insurance Institute in Prague. His reports on accident prevention included illustrations of safety devices for wood-planing machines D. Dougie Jones, the emptied Cooper, is an agent at Lucky 7 Insurance in Las Vegas. He rescues the firm by scrawling ladders and lines across case files, which his superiors read as diagrams of fraud C. The holy fool of *The Return* works in Kafka's profession. In a series set in and around a logging town, the patron saint of insurance is the author who drew safety guards for woodworking machines.

Kafka's Odradek, from "The Cares of a Family Man" (1919), is a spool-shaped creature that cannot die and laughs a laugh without lungs. It has a Lynchian cousin in the Arm's evolved form in *The Return*: a leafless tree topped by a fleshy, brain-like knot that speaks C.

The Elephant Man (1980) transposes the Kafkaesque body into history and the institution. Its first image of John Merrick is withheld behind a curtain, which the showman Bytes draws back for the surgeon Frederick Treves. The film's structure then follows that curtain as it migrates from the freak show into the hospital H. Treves exhibits Merrick to the Pathological Society as a specimen. The hospital, ostensibly a refuge, becomes a second exhibition space when a night porter charges admission to drunken visitors. Michel Foucault's *The Birth of the Clinic* (1963) described the medical gaze as a regime that constitutes the body as an object of knowledge. Lynch's film shows that gaze as continuous with the gaze of the fairground. The hospital, the institution that should shield the split body, reproduces the exhibition it was meant to end.

Merrick's body also belongs to the lineage of Francis Bacon discussed in the Introduction H. It is the Figure isolated within a frame and exposed to a gaze, flesh in revolt against the human form. The film's opening frames the deformity as the trace of a primal violence, a nightmare in which elephants trample his mother before his birth. Cornered by a crowd in a railway station, Merrick cries out that he is not an animal but a human being. It is the only moment in Lynch's work where the Kafkaesque question of the boundary between species is asked in a fully humanist key. Chapter Seven will argue that the film's ending answers it from the Field.

2.5

Mirrors, Keys, and Radios: Buñuel, Deren, Cocteau

The cinematic genealogy of the Split begins with a razor. Luis Buñuel and Salvador Dalí's *Un Chien Andalou* (1929) opens with a blade drawn across an eye. Its intertitles mark time with absurd precision ("Once upon a time," "Eight years later," "Around three in the morning," "Sixteen years before") while the images ignore them entirely. Two features of the film enter Lynch's work directly H. The first is the ants, already discussed, that issue from a wound in a palm. The second is the dislocation of chronology from experience. That dislocation governs the time-loops of *Lost Highway* and culminates in the question with which *The Return* ends.

André Breton's first *Manifesto of Surrealism* (1924) defined surrealism as pure psychic automatism: thought dictated in the absence of any control exercised by reason. The resemblance to Lynch's caught ideas is evident, but the difference is more instructive H. Surrealist automatism descends into the personal unconscious of Freudian theory, while Lynch's fishing descends into a field that is impersonal and, in his account, blissful. The surrealist trusts the unconscious to speak; Lynch insists that the artist must stay faithful to the idea once caught and translate it with conscious care. The surrealist depth is psychological; the Lynchian depth is metaphysical.

This is why Lynch's surrealism, unlike Buñuel's, has no programmatic political target. Buñuel's later films indict the bourgeoisie. The dinner guests of *The Exterminating Angel* (1962) cannot leave a room for reasons no one can name. The diners of *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie* (1972) are interrupted by dreams within dreams. Lynch's critique of the American surface is not class critique but ontological diagnosis. When it touches the political, as in the Cold War domestic containment of *Blue Velvet*, it does so because the political is one of the forms containment takes. In its base materialism (its vomit, creamed corn, and decaying flesh), Lynch's surrealism is closer to Georges Bataille's dissident doctrine of the formless than to Breton's convulsive beauty. Chapter Four develops this point through Bataille's economics of excess.

Maya Deren and Alexander Hammid's *Meshes of the Afternoon* (1943) is the most direct cinematic ancestor of *Lost Highway* and *Mulholland Drive* H. A woman returns home, falls asleep, and enters a loop in which the same objects recur in shifting relations: a key, a knife, a flower, a telephone off the hook. A hooded figure with a mirror for a face walks ahead of her and cannot be overtaken. Multiple versions of the woman gather around a table. The film ends with her body discovered dead in a chair.

Each element has a Lynchian descendant:

- the key that opens the loop becomes the blue key of *Mulholland Drive*;
- the figure whose face reflects the viewer becomes the Mystery Man of *Lost Highway*;

- the woman multiplied around the table becomes Betty and Diane;
- the death in the chair becomes Diane's suicide in her bed.

Lost Highway's own loop renders Deren's structure as a Möbius strip. At the film's beginning Fred Madison hears "Dick Laurent is dead" through his intercom, and at the end he speaks the same words into it.

Deren's later work deepens the connection. Her ethnography of Haitian Vodou, *Divine Horsemen* (1953), describes possession as the *lwa* "riding" the possessed person, who becomes the god's "horse." BOB's relation to Leland, and the Lodge spirits' relation to their hosts, is possession in this precise sense: not madness but occupation C.

There is, finally, the matter of a name. The filmmaker who gave American cinema its founding dream-loop chose to be called Maya. The constellational method cannot claim this as intention, but it can record it as rhyme: the first American cinema of the veil was made by a woman who bore the name of the veil.

Jean Cocteau completes the genealogy and supplies Lynch with two of his most important devices H. In *The Blood of a Poet* (1930), the poet passes through a mirror into a hotel corridor and spies through its keyholes on scenes of ritual and violence. This is Jeffrey Beaumont's position in Dorothy's closet: the voyeur-initiate behind a slatted door. In *Orphée* (1950), mirrors are explicitly the doors through which Death comes and goes. The underworld is a ruined Zone through which Orpheus follows Death's emissaries, motorcyclists in black leather. The poet becomes obsessed with cryptic phrases broadcast over a car radio, among them "The bird sings with its fingers," and transcribes them as poetry, unaware that a dead rival is transmitting them from beyond. Cocteau said the broadcasts were inspired by the coded messages the BBC sent to the French Resistance D.

The radio of *Orphée* has three descendants in *Twin Peaks*:

- Major Briggs's deep-space telemetry, which yields fragments such as "The owls are not what they seem" and the repeated name of Cooper;
- the Log Lady's log, which receives messages from the forest;
- the Woodsman of Part 8, who seizes a radio station in 1956 and broadcasts an incantation that drives its listeners into unconsciousness.

Cocteau also dramatizes the sinister form of the *śruti* theory of authorship discussed in Chapter One. Orpheus's poems are received rather than composed, but their source is the realm of death. Lynch's fish rise from the Field and Cocteau's transmissions rise from the underworld. *Twin Peaks* is the work in which one can no longer be sure which is which.

A final American hinge connects this European line to Lynch: Hitchcock's *Vertigo* (1958). A man falls in love with Madeleine, who turns out to be a performance by an-

other woman, Judy, and he then compels Judy to become Madeleine again. The split woman of *Vertigo*, idealized image and degraded original, governs *Mulholland Drive*. Chapter Three examines the echo of her name: the "Judy" whom Phillip Jeffries refuses to discuss in *Fire Walk with Me*, and whom *The Return* reveals as an extreme negative force.

2.6

The Barred Subject: Lacan's Mirror and the Obscene Father

Jacques Lacan's mirror stage, first presented in 1936 and published in definitive form in 1949, gives the European theory of the split its most consequential formulation. The infant, still physically uncoordinated, experiences its body as fragmented (*corps morcelé*). Seeing a unified image of itself in the mirror, it assumes that image with jubilation. The ego is constituted in that moment as an alienated identification with an external image. The reflection is the first double, and the self is from the outset a fiction of unity laid over a body in pieces.

Lynch's cinema is an archive of the *corps morcelé* H:

- the severed ear;
- the head that falls from Henry Spencer's shoulders in *Eraserhead* and is carried to a factory to be processed into pencil erasers;
- the one-armed man;
- the headless male body found, in the first part of *The Return*, in a South Dakota apartment, bearing the head of a murdered librarian.

Lynch's mirrors therefore do not confirm identity but expose its fragility. They are the surfaces through which BOB looks out.

Lacan's later theory of the paternal function supplies the frame for Žižek's and Mulvey's readings of Lynch's fathers. The symbolic father, the Name-of-the-Father, institutes law and prohibition. Its obscene underside is the father of enjoyment, who violates the law he embodies and demands an unbearable jouissance. Lynch's fathers divide exactly along this line:

- **The wounded or benevolent fathers:** Tom Beaumont struck down in his garden, Sheriff Truman, Major Briggs.
- **The obscene fathers:** Frank Booth; Mr. Eddy, who beats a tailgating motorist nearly to death in the name of traffic safety; Leland Palmer as BOB's host.

This split in the paternal function is the precondition of the Lynchian plot. The good father is wounded or absent, and the son descends into a world ruled by the obscene one.

Chapter Six will argue that the Grail romances encode the same structure as the wound of the Fisher King.

2.7

The Lynchian Difference: From Psychology to Cosmology

The European genealogy gives Lynch an exhaustive phenomenology of fission:

- from Hoffmann and Freud, the threatened eye and the return of the hidden;
- from Jentsch, Bergson, and Hoffmann's Olympia, the ambiguously animate body;
- from Rank, Poe, Dostoevsky, and Stevenson, the double as conscience, rival, and extract;
- from Kafka, Bacon, and the clinic, the body under sentence;
- from Buñuel, Deren, and Cocteau, the mirror, the key, the loop, and the radio;
- from Lacan, the subject as constitutively barred.

Every one of these motifs is present in Lynch, many in their most extreme form. What Lynch adds is a change in the ontological status of the split.

In the European tradition, the double is a psychic projection (Rank, Freud), a moral allegory (Poe, Stevenson), a social symptom (Dostoevsky), or a structural necessity (Lacan). In every case it is an event in the subject. In Lynch it is an event in the Field. This follows from the physics of consciousness reconstructed in Chapter One. If there is no ultimate distinction between psychic and physical reality, then a split in the psyche is also a split in matter, and a projection can acquire a body.

This is why Lynch's doubles do what no psychoanalytic double can: they walk, drive, eat, and kill independently of their originals. When Fred Madison becomes Pete Dayton in *Lost Highway*, the transformation is not narrated as hallucination. The guards open a locked cell on death row and find a different man inside. The prison, the most absolute containment structure the state possesses, cannot contain the split, because the split has occurred at a level beneath the distinction between mind and walls. The European tradition knew that the self could divide. Lynch's cosmology adds that when the self divides, the world divides with it.

This difference marks the passage from the genealogy of fission to its history. If psychic splitting is cosmic, there must have been a moment when the cosmic split first occurred on the scale of the world. Lynch locates that moment precisely: in the New Mexico desert, at 5:29 a.m. on 16 July 1945.

CHAPTER THREE

Trinity

FISSION, ELECTRICITY, AND THE ATOMIC THEOGONY OF PART 8

3

The flash that released the destroyer also called forth the one who would be destroyed in order to defeat him.

§ 3.2

3.1 The Gadget, the Sonnet, and the Gita
3.2 Into the Cloud: Part 8 as Theogony
3.3 1956: The Broadcast, the Egg, and the Anti-Mantra
3.4 The Containment Era, 1945–1947
3.5 The Glass Box: Containment Breached
3.6 Current: From the Over-Soul to the Grid
3.7 Blue and Red: The Colors of Fission
3.8 Judy: Night, the Mother of Ills
3.9 Consequences

3.1

The Gadget, the Sonnet, and the Gita

At 5:29 a.m. on 16 July 1945, a plutonium implosion device its makers called "the Gadget" was detonated atop a steel tower. The site lay in a stretch of the New Mexico desert that the Spanish had named the Jornada del Muerto, the journey of the dead man. The test had a theological name. J. Robert Oppenheimer later wrote to General Leslie Groves that he had chosen "Trinity" with John Donne in mind, in particular the Holy Sonnet that begins "Batter my heart, three-person'd God" D.

The sonnet is a prayer for violent grace. Its speaker complains that God has so far only knocked, breathed, shone, and sought to mend, and asks instead that God "break, blow, burn, and make me new." The first nuclear explosion was thus christened with a prayer that the soul be shattered in order to be remade. Donne's verbs describe fission with uncanny precision. The irony runs deeper still. The Christian Trinity, three persons in one substance, is the paradigmatic Western figure of a unity that contains division without being destroyed by it. It lent its name to the event that demonstrated that the unity of matter could be destroyed.

Oppenheimer's second sacred text was Indian D. He had studied Sanskrit at Berkeley with Arthur Ryder and read the *Bhagavad Gītā* in the original. In its eleventh chapter, Krishna reveals his universal form to Arjuna on the battlefield, and two of its verses attached themselves to the test in later accounts. The first (11.12) compares the radiance of the divine form to a thousand suns rising at once in the sky. Oppenheimer is reported to have recalled it at the moment of the flash, and Robert Jungk took the title of his history of the bomb, *Brighter than a Thousand Suns* (1956), from it. The second (11.32) is the line Oppenheimer recited in a 1965 television documentary, which he rendered "Now I am become Death, the destroyer of worlds." The Sanskrit word he translated as "Death" is *kāla*, which also means Time: the god on the battlefield is Time grown ripe for the destruction of the worlds. Chapter Six will return to this identity of death and time, because *The Return* ends with a question about the year.

The test therefore stood at the intersection of the two genealogies this dissertation has reconstructed. Its name came from the Christian tradition of the One-in-Three. Its revelation came from the Vedantic tradition of the One-in-All. Both were invoked to sanctify an act that split the one.

A third utterance completes the scene. Kenneth Bainbridge, the test's director, reportedly told Oppenheimer immediately afterward that now they were all sons of bitches. The sacred verse and the profane remark, spoken over the same fireball, are the sublime and its ridiculous double at the instant of their common birth H. In one sense, Lynch's career consists of holding both utterances in a single image.

Part 8 of *The Return*, broadcast on 25 June 2017, scores its reconstruction of Trinity with Krzysztof Penderecki's *Threnody to the Victims of Hiroshima*. The composition's history supplies one more detail [D]. Penderecki first titled the piece *8′37″*, after its duration, and dedicated it to the victims of Hiroshima only after hearing it performed. Its meaning arrived after it was made. The music of Lynch's atomic theogony is thus a work with a retroactive dedication. Retroactivity, the attempt to reach back and alter the meaning of what has already occurred, is precisely the structure whose failure *The Return* will finally dramatize.

3.2

Into the Cloud: Part 8 as Theogony

Part 8 begins conventionally and then abandons convention altogether. First, Mr. C is shot and then revived by soot-blackened figures who paw at his body until an orb bearing BOB's face rises from it. Then Nine Inch Nails perform at the Roadhouse. Then a title card announces White Sands, New Mexico, 16 July 1945, and the explosion follows.

The camera does not observe the mushroom cloud from a safe distance, as every documentary image of the bomb had done. It travels into the cloud and keeps traveling for several minutes, through roiling fire into abstract fields of particles and light, while Penderecki's strings cluster and shriek. This reverses both Emerson's transparent eyeball and Burke's sublime [H]. Emerson's eye receives the currents of Universal Being in the calm of the woods; Lynch's camera enters the place where those currents are torn. Burke's sublime requires a safe distance from the terrible object; Lynch's camera abolishes the distance. The spectator does not contemplate fission but is carried into it.

Within the cloud the episode becomes a cosmogony:

- **The Experiment.** An entity credited as "Experiment," the same figure that broke out of the glass box in the series' first part, floats in a dark void and emits a stream of matter. The stream contains eggs and an orb bearing BOB's face.
- **The Woodsmen.** Near a desert gas station, flickering in and out of visibility, soot-black figures appear, moving with the jerky irregularity of damaged film.
- **The Fireman.** In a monochrome palace atop a rock surrounded by sea, a tall figure later identified as the Fireman watches the explosion and its consequences on a screen in a vast hall. He then rises into the air, and a golden stream issues from his head and coalesces into an orb bearing the face of Laura Palmer.
- **Señorita Dido.** A woman kisses Laura's orb and releases it toward the earth.

The structure is that of Hesiod's *Theogony*, with a precision this dissertation offers as a strong constellation [H][C]. In Hesiod, Kronos castrates the primordial sky-father

Ouranos with a sickle. The drops of blood that fall upon Gaia, the earth, engender, among others, the Erinyes, the avenging Furies. The severed genitals fall into the sea, and from the foam that gathers around them Aphrodite is born. A single primal cut thus produces offspring of opposite natures and opposite birthplaces: vengeance from the earth, love from the sea.

Part 8 reproduces this structure exactly. The primal cut is fission, the splitting of matter at its foundations, and Chapter Two has already shown that Lynch's imagination links the severed organ to castration. From the earth, in the desert of the dead man's journey, comes BOB, the bringer of pain. From the sea, in the Fireman's tower on its rock, comes Laura. The Fireman does not create Laura from nothing; he produces her in response to the same catastrophe that produced BOB. She is Aphrodite to BOB's Erinyes, born of the same wound.

This reading reorganizes the entire *Twin Peaks* narrative retroactively. Viewers in 1990 met Laura Palmer as a corpse wrapped in plastic, the murdered homecoming queen whose secret life the investigation uncovers. Part 8 reveals her as a being sent into the world to counter an evil released at Trinity, and therefore as a figure whose suffering has cosmic significance. Chapter Four develops the Gnostic dimension of this revelation: Laura as Sophia, the divine spark sent down into a world of matter governed by predatory powers. Here it is enough to observe that Lynch's theogony gives the American century a double origin. The flash that released the destroyer also called forth the one who would be destroyed in order to defeat him.

3.3

1956: The Broadcast, the Egg, and the Anti-Mantra

The episode's final movement jumps to New Mexico in 1956. An egg hatches in the desert, releasing a creature that is part frog and part insect. A teenage boy walks a girl home through the desert night; she finds a penny, heads up, and calls it lucky. Woodsmen descend on the region. One approaches a stopped car and repeats a single question to its terrified occupants: "Got a light?"

Another enters the local radio station, which is playing the Platters' "My Prayer." He kills the receptionist and the disc jockey by crushing their skulls and takes the microphone. He then broadcasts a repetitive incantation that begins "This is the water, and this is the well." Across the town, everyone listening falls unconscious, including the girl in her bedroom. The frog-insect crawls through her window and into her mouth as she sleeps. The girl is widely identified as Sarah Palmer, Laura's future mother, although the series never states this explicitly.

Three features of the sequence complete the theogony.

The first is the broadcast itself, the dark twin of Transcendental Meditation C. TM uses a mantra, a sound without semantic content repeated silently, to settle the mind through progressively quieter states until it transcends thought. The Woodsman uses an incantation, rhythmic, repetitive, and semantically opaque, broadcast loudly through a mass medium, to collapse his listeners into unconsciousness. The Vedantic distinction between deep sleep and transcendence, which Chapter Five develops through the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*, is decisive here. Both states are undifferentiated, but only transcendence is awake. The Woodsman's broadcast is an anti-mantra: it produces the undifferentiation of sleep in place of the undifferentiation of awareness, and in that defenseless sleep the creature enters. The station had been playing a prayer, and the Woodsman replaces it with a mantra of stupor.

The second is the medium. In 1956, radio and the newer medium of television were binding the American household into a national audience. In Lynch's theogony that network becomes a vector of possession. The Woodsman needs no physical access to the girl, only a transmitter and her listening. Cocteau's radio brought poetry from the dead to the poet (Chapter Two); this radio brings sleep from the Lodge to the American bedroom. The domestic interior, the core of the containment culture, is penetrated not by breaking its walls but through the device it invited in.

The third is the year C. On 29 June 1956, Eisenhower signed the Federal-Aid Highway Act, establishing the National System of Interstate and Defense Highways. The network was justified in part as Cold War infrastructure for military movement and civilian evacuation. The Woodsmen arrive in the year the American landscape began to be overlaid with the roads Lynch's cinema would make its own. *Lost Highway* opens with the yellow center line of a road rushing out of darkness; *Wild at Heart* is a road film; *Mulholland Drive* is named for a road. The highway in Lynch is the containment era's own nervous system, built for flight from the bomb, and the lost highway is the road on which no flight is possible.

3.4

The Containment Era, 1945–1947

Lynch was born on 20 January 1946 in Missoula, Montana, roughly six months after Trinity. The constellational method does not require that a biographical date mean anything in itself; it requires only that we read what clusters around it. What clusters around this one is the founding of the containment era in every register:

16 JULY 1945:
the Trinity test, followed three weeks later by Hiroshima and Nagasaki.

JANUARY–MARCH 1946:

in Pasadena, the rocket engineer and occultist Jack Parsons, with L. Ron Hubbard, performs the ritual sequence known as the Babalon Working.

22 FEBRUARY 1946:
George Kennan sends the Long Telegram, the founding document of containment.

5 MARCH 1946:
at Fulton, Missouri, Winston Churchill declares that an iron curtain has descended across Europe.

JUNE 1947:
the *Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists* introduces the Doomsday Clock. In Washington State, the Maury Island incident is reported on Puget Sound, and Kenneth Arnold reports nine shining objects near Mount Rainier, giving the world the "flying saucer."

JULY 1947:
the Roswell incident in New Mexico; Kennan's "X" article; the National Security Act.

The geography is as telling as the chronology. The bomb and Roswell belong to New Mexico, the setting of Part 8. The UFO wave began in Washington State, the setting of *Twin Peaks*. Mark Frost's paratextual *The Secret History of Twin Peaks* (2016) folds precisely this ferment into the town's prehistory: sightings over the Cascades, Pacific Northwest anomalies, and Pasadena rocket-occultists become the explicit backstory of the Lodges D. The series had already given Major Briggs a past in Project Blue Book, the Air Force's investigation of unidentified flying objects (1952–1969). The FBI's own paranormal designation, the Blue Rose cases, echoes that program's name.

Churchill's image deserves particular attention C. The founding metaphor of the Cold War is a curtain. Behind it, in the American imagination of the following decade, lay the Reds, whose infiltration of the homeland was the obsession of the Red Scare. Chapter One identified the red curtain as the theatrical form of the veil of Māyā; the containment era supplies its political form. Lynch's Red Room is a space behind red curtains from which possessing entities emerge to infiltrate American homes. It is the return of this repressed in metaphysical form. Lynch keeps the enemy behind the curtain but makes it older than any ideology and more intimate than any spy.

Elaine Tyler May opens *Homeward Bound* (1988) with an emblem of domestic containment: a young couple who, in 1959, spent their honeymoon sealed inside a backyard fallout shelter, an event *Life* magazine featured. Marriage, sexuality, and nuclear dread are enclosed in a single underground chamber. The image could serve as an epigraph to *Blue Velvet*, whose opening descent beneath the suburban lawn finds what the shelter was built to keep out. What lies down there is not radiation but the violence and sexuality that domestic containment existed to seal away.

The broadcast dates of the original *Twin Peaks* supply a final coincidence C. The series premiered on 8 April 1990, five months after the opening of the Berlin Wall. It concluded on 10 June 1991, six months before the dissolution of the Soviet Union. *Twin Peaks* aired, in other words, while the iron curtain was lifting and the containment order was dissolving. It ended with Cooper trapped in the Red Room and his double loose in the world. The containment era closed with the release of the contained.

3.5

The Glass Box: Containment Breached

After a brief prologue in the Lodge, *The Return* opens with a literal containment structure. On an upper floor of a Manhattan skyscraper, a large glass box stands in an empty room, surrounded by cameras and lights and funded by an anonymous billionaire. A young man named Sam is paid to watch it and to change the cameras' memory cards; he does not know what he is watching for. One night a young woman, Tracey, slips past the absent guard to visit him, and they become intimate on the couch facing the box. The box darkens, and the Experiment materializes inside it, breaks through the glass, and kills them both.

The scene is the series' thesis statement, and it is a theory of the medium H. The glass box is a containment vessel monitored by cameras, and the watcher's task is the dull, repetitive surveillance of something that does not appear. That is exactly the television viewer's position before the screen, itself a glass surface enclosing a luminous space. Lynch's opening makes the viewer a containment technician and the screen a containment wall, and then shows the wall failing.

The trigger is pointed. The breach occurs when the watchers stop watching and turn toward each other's bodies. In the containment economy, sexuality is the distraction through which the contained escapes. The same holds for the domestic containment May describes, in which regulated sexuality was meant to keep greater dangers sealed away.

The image belongs to a lineage of late-twentieth-century fictions in which the screen becomes a membrane. In David Cronenberg's *Videodrome* (1983), the television bulges and breathes. In Hideo Nakata's *Ringu* (1998), a murdered girl crawls out of a television set to kill its viewer. Lynch's glass box is the most austere version of this conceit. It has no broadcast, no tape, and no signal; it is simply an empty transparent volume, watched until something arrives in it. It is the screen and the containment vessel each reduced to its essence, and Lynch's point is that they are the same object.

3.6

Current: From the Over-Soul to the Grid

Chapter One argued that Lynch accepts TM's identification of the unified field of physics with the field of consciousness. On that view, electricity is not a metaphor for spiritual current but spiritual current itself. The history of the electrical grid supports this reading more directly than one might expect D C.

In 1896 Swami Vivekananda, the first great teacher of Vedānta in the United States, met Nikola Tesla in New York. Vivekananda wrote afterward that Tesla had been struck by the Vedantic concepts of *prāṇa* (force) and *ākāśa* (the subtle substance of space). Tesla believed, Vivekananda reported, that he could demonstrate mathematically that force and matter reduce to potential energy, which would place Vedantic cosmology on a scientific footing. Tesla's system of alternating current became the basis of the modern electrical grid, so the grid was born partly in conversation with Vedānta. Tesla later claimed to have received rhythmic signals from beyond the earth at Colorado Springs in 1899, and he built at Wardenclyffe a tower meant to transmit energy wirelessly through the planet. Major Briggs's deep-space messages and the Fireman's tower are the Lynchian afterlives of these projects.

A casting coincidence turns this genealogy into a constellation C. In *Fire Walk with Me* (1992), David Bowie plays Phillip Jeffries, the FBI agent who vanishes into the realm of the Lodges and reappears amid electrical discharges. In Christopher Nolan's *The Prestige* (2006), Bowie plays Tesla himself. In that film, Tesla's electrical machine does not transport its subject but duplicates him, so every use produces a double. By the time of *The Return*, completed after Bowie's death, Phillip Jeffries has become a machine: a great bell-shaped apparatus that speaks through steam and displays numbers in smoke. The actor who played the founder of the grid also played the agent dissolved into it, and the film in which he played the founder makes electricity a machine for producing doubles.

Electricity in Lynch is pervasive and consistently ambivalent:

- **Flickering lights.** The flickering fluorescent tube in the morgue of the *Twin Peaks* pilot was a defect Lynch chose to keep, an accident caught rather than an effect designed. Thereafter, lights flicker whenever the Lodge is near.
- **The humming pole.** Utility pole number 6, in *Fire Walk with Me* and again in *The Return*, emits an audible hum at sites of violence and death.
- **The outlet.** In Part 3, Cooper exits the Lodge through an electrical outlet in a Las Vegas house.
- **The electric chair.** In *Lost Highway*, Fred Madison is sentenced to death in the electric chair and escapes the sentence only by splitting into Pete Dayton before it

can be carried out.

- **The fork.** In Part 15, the inert Dougie Jones hears the name "Gordon Cole" spoken in *Sunset Boulevard* on television, crawls to a wall socket, and pushes a fork into it. The shock nearly kills him and restores Dale Cooper.

The same current carries BOB between bodies and wakes Cooper from twenty-five years of exile. This ambivalence is not inconsistency; it follows from the physics of the Field. Electric current flows only across a potential difference. A perfectly unified field, with no difference anywhere within it, would carry no current. Current is the Field's energy flowing across a split. Lynchian electricity is therefore the energy of the One made available only by its division. It is neither good nor evil but the medium in which both move, and possession and awakening travel by the same wire.

This is also why Lynch's electricity is alternating. Emerson's currents of the Universal Being circulate without polarity. The American grid's current reverses at sixty cycles per second and leaves an audible signature: a low hum wherever transformers and fluorescent fixtures operate. Chapter One read the chevron floor of the Red Room as the notation of this oscillation.

Lynch's soundtracks rest on such drones. Chapter Five will connect the continuous tone to the Vedic syllable that the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* treats as the sound of all states of consciousness, and Chapter Seven will connect it to the unstruck sound beyond them. For the argument of this chapter, the hum is the sound of the Emersonian current after Trinity: polarized, harnessed, and humming in the walls of every American house.

The oldest Western philosophy of energy anticipated this structure. Heraclitus called the cosmos an ever-living fire, kindled and quenched in measures (fragment B30), and declared that the thunderbolt steers all things (B64). *Fire Walk with Me* takes its title from an incantation that makes fire a companion on the road. This is a Heraclitean cosmos, in which fire is both destroyer and the substance of order, and in which lightning, electricity's purest form, governs the world.

3.7

Blue and Red: The Colors of Fission

Lynch's palette is not decorative but cosmological. Its two dominant colors correspond to the two products of fission C.

Red is the color of the energy released: fission as force, heat, and appetite, the energy that feeds the Lodge. It appears in the curtains and the Red Room, in the fire engine of *Blue Velvet*'s opening, in the flames that fill the screen in *Wild at Heart*'s credits, and in the political Reds behind the iron curtain.

Blue is the color of the product made, the thing that should not exist. In *Fire Walk with Me*, a dancer named Lil wears a blue rose pinned to her dress as part of Gordon Cole's coded briefing, and the FBI's paranormal files are the Blue Rose cases. *The Return* explains the designation. Albert recounts a 1975 case in which a woman named Lois Duffy shot a woman identical to herself; the dying one said she was like the blue rose and then vanished. A blue rose does not occur in nature, so the Blue Rose cases are cases of the conjured double: a being produced rather than born, which *The Return* calls a tulpa (Chapter Five). In *Mulholland Drive*, the blue box and blue key open the passage from Diane's dream to her waking ruin. At Club Silencio, a woman with blue hair, watching from a balcony, speaks the film's final word.

Two facts from the history of science, offered as constellation, deepen the identification. The first is Cherenkov radiation, discovered by Pavel Cherenkov in 1934 and recognized with a Nobel Prize in 1958. It is the eerie blue glow in the water of nuclear reactor pools, where charged particles travel faster than light can travel in water. Blue is literally the visible light of fission in containment. The second is the blue rose itself. In 2004, after years of genetic engineering, a Japanese-Australian collaboration announced the first rose that produces blue pigment, a flower that could not exist until technology rewrote its code. The impossible object that names the FBI's fission cases was made real by the same century's mastery of nature's foundations.

Red and blue, energy and product, are the two colors of the split, and Lynch uses them consistently enough to turn the palette into a cosmology. The opening credits of *Blue Velvet* pass from the blue of the curtain to the red of the roses. In its first seconds, the film sets both products of fission before the eye.

3.8

Judy: Night, the Mother of Ills

Chapter Two promised a return to the name Judy, and the atomic theogony is the place to fulfill that promise.

In Hitchcock's *Vertigo*, Judy is the real woman beneath the idealized Madeleine. She is a shopgirl hired to impersonate a wealthy man's wife and then remade by the detective who loved the impersonation. She dies falling from a mission bell tower, as Hoffmann's Nathanael died falling from a tower. Judy is what lies behind the image: the material, compromised, and finally destroyed woman whom the fantasy covered.

Lynch's Judy is first mentioned in *Fire Walk with Me* by Phillip Jeffries, who arrives at FBI headquarters in terror and insists that they will not talk about Judy at all. In the final parts of *The Return*, Gordon Cole explains that he, Major Briggs, and Jeffries discovered an extreme negative force, called in ancient times Jowday, a name that over time

became Judy. In the series' last hour, Cooper, searching for Laura in an altered world, enters a coffee shop in Odessa, Texas, called Judy's.

Many viewers and critics identify Judy with the Experiment, the entity that emitted BOB in Part 8 and broke through the glass box in Part 1. The series encourages this identification but does not confirm it, and the present argument does not depend on it. What matters is the structure the name encodes H. In *Vertigo*, Judy is the reality behind the image. In Lynch, Judy is the force behind the forces: older than BOB, unnameable by those who have encountered her, and present at last in the very texture of the world where the series ends. In the terms of this dissertation she is the negative pole of the Field, the Schopenhauerian Will at its most concentrated, the hunger the Black Lodge serves.

Hesiod supplies her mythological form C. Immediately after the castration of Ouranos, the *Theogony* lists the children Nyx, Night, bore without a partner. Among them are Doom, Death, Sleep, the tribe of Dreams, Blame, Woe, the Fates, Nemesis, Deceit, Old Age, and Strife. Night is the mother of every ill, and her children include Sleep and Dreams, the very states the Woodsman's broadcast induces and the Lodge inhabits. Judy is Lynch's Nyx, the nocturnal mother whose brood fills the containment era's sleep.

If Nocturnal Transcendentalism has a dark pole, it is Judy. The Fireman, in his tower amid the sea, sends Laura into the world. Night, in the desert, sends everything else.

3.9

Consequences

The atomic theogony of Part 8 has four consequences for the argument of this dissertation.

First, it confirms that Lynch's cosmology is cosmic rather than psychological. The origin of evil in *Twin Peaks* is not a trauma within a family. It is a wound in the Field, inflicted at a datable moment by an identifiable act.

Second, it locates the containment era as the historical matrix of Lynch's imagery. His curtains, highways, radios, electrical hums, glass screens, and colors are the furniture of the period that began with Trinity and the Long Telegram and ended, more or less, as *Twin Peaks* went off the air.

Third, it gives electricity its precise metaphysical status. Electricity is the Field's energy flowing across a split. It is ambivalent by nature, and it is therefore the medium of both possession and awakening.

Fourth, it reveals the Lynchian cosmos as a war of offspring. The cut at Trinity produced both the destroyer and the one sent to oppose him, who would be destroyed in

doing so.

The question that follows is economic. If fission releases energy, and if beings born of fission feed upon it, then the Lynchian cosmos must have a political economy: a system of production, extraction, and consumption in which human suffering is the commodity. In the Lodge's own language, that economy is called *garmonbozia*.

CHAPTER FOUR

4

Garmonbozia

AFFECTIVE EXTRACTION, ELEUSIS, AND THE WOMAN IN TROUBLE

After twenty-seven years of garmonbozia, the series ends with a remainder that will not be eaten.

§ 4.8

4.1 The Word and the Debt
4.2 Annam: Eater and Eaten
4.3 The Murdered Maiden and the Grain
4.4 Eleusis: An Ear of Grain Reaped in Silence
4.5 The Archons' Harvest
4.6 The Accursed Share
4.7 Timber and Celluloid
4.8 The Woman in Trouble
4.9 From Economy to Self

4.1

The Word and the Debt

Garmonbozia is one of the few words Lynch invented, and the film that introduces it glosses it explicitly. In the final sequence of *Fire Walk with Me*, BOB and Leland Palmer stand in the Red Room before MIKE, the one-armed man, and the Arm, his severed limb now embodied as the Man from Another Place. MIKE and the Arm demand of BOB "all my garmonbozia." A subtitle translates the word as pain and sorrow, and BOB settles the debt, drawing blood from Leland's wounded body. Elsewhere the substance takes visible form as creamed corn. In the second season, Donna Hayward takes over Laura's Meals on Wheels route and delivers a tray to the bedridden Mrs. Tremond, who complains about the creamed corn. It vanishes from the plate and reappears in the hands of her masked grandson.

Three features of the word set the terms of this chapter.

- **Garmonbozia is food.** What the Lodge's inhabitants eat is human suffering.
- **Garmonbozia is owed.** The Red Room scene is a collection. MIKE and the Arm present a claim against BOB, who has evidently been harvesting on their behalf and withholding the yield. MIKE had once called BOB his partner, before a religious conversion led him to cut off his tattooed arm. The Lodge therefore has an economy, with producers, extractors, creditors, and debts, and its unit of value is pain.
- **Garmonbozia appears on a precise route** (D for the textual facts, C for the reading). The first creamed corn in *Twin Peaks* materializes on Laura Palmer's Meals on Wheels route, the circuit along which the murdered girl had carried food to the town's elderly. The food of the Lodge appears exactly where the dead girl used to feed the living.

This chapter argues that garmonbozia is the master concept of a Lynchian political economy H C. Its structure recurs with remarkable consistency across several traditions:

- Indian, Greek, Indonesian, and Native American myths of a murdered woman whose body becomes food;
- the Gnostic cosmology of archons who harvest the light of a fallen Sophia;
- twentieth-century esoteric and horror fictions of beings who farm human emotion;
- Georges Bataille's theory of the accursed share;
- the real extractive economies, timber and Hollywood, that Lynch's narratives inhabit.

4.2

Annam: Eater and Eaten

Chapter One noted that the *Taittirīya Upaniṣad* arranges the self in five sheaths, from food at the outermost to bliss at the innermost. Its third chapter identifies food with Brahman: beings are born from food, live by food, and return to food. The Upaniṣad ends with an extraordinary song (3.10.6), sung by the one who has realized the Self: I am food, I am food, I am food; I am the eater of food, the eater of food, the eater of food. In the Field, eater and eaten are one. The song is the alimentary form of the doctrine that Chapter One traced through the *Gītā*'s slayer and slain, Emerson's red slayer, and Schopenhauer's tormentor and tormented. Where the Self is realized, predation is a single act of the One feeding itself.

The Black Lodge is the fission of this song H. It separates eater from eaten absolutely: BOB and the Arm eat, and Laura is eaten. It also feeds at the outermost sheath, on pain and sorrow, the affective residue of the body, rather than reaching the bliss at the core. The Upaniṣadic sage who knows himself as food is liberated by that knowledge, whereas the Lodge's victim, divided from her eater, is merely consumed. Schopenhauer's Will is the philosophical name for this condition: it feeds on its own appearances because it cannot see through the veil that divides them. BOB is a Will that eats without knowing that it is eating itself.

Christianity supplies the complementary figure. In the Gospel of John (12:24), Jesus says that a grain must fall into the ground and die if it is to bear fruit. The King James Version renders the saying with a word that matters here: "Except a corn of wheat fall into the ground and die, it abideth alone." The grain that dies is resurrected as harvest, and the Eucharist completes the cycle by making the body of the sacrificed one into bread.

Garmonbozia inverts this economy C. The Lodge does not let the grain fall and rise; it eats it. In the language of agrarian prudence, the Lodge eats the seed corn: it consumes the very substance that should have been planted for the future. Its victims, almost always young, are that future.

Lynch's cinema is accordingly organized around two cuisines.

- **The sacramental cuisine belongs to the town.** It includes Cooper's coffee and cherry pie at the Double R, the doughnuts stacked in the sheriff's station, and the pie the emptied Cooper devours as Dougie Jones. These are foods of communion, eaten in company; Chapter One read the doughnut as Lynch's emblem of plenitude.
- **The infernal cuisine belongs to the underworld.** It includes the "man-made" chickens of *Eraserhead* that bleed under the knife, the creamed corn of the Lodge,

and the coffee Cooper is offered in the Red Room at the end of the second season, which congeals in its cup into an opaque sludge.

The myth of Persephone supplies the rule that governs the second cuisine. Abducted to the underworld, Persephone eats a few pomegranate seeds there, and that meal binds her to return to the dead each year. Food of the underworld is never to be consumed, and Cooper does not drink the Lodge's coffee.

The creamed corn also invites a material reading C. It is not grain in its natural form but a processed, canned commodity of American industrial agriculture, and Lynch was the son of a research scientist with the Department of Agriculture. The Lodge does not eat bread, the ancient sacramental form of grain. It eats the product of the postwar food industry, sweet, soft, uniform, and sealed in a can. The food of demons is the food of the containment economy.

4.3

The Murdered Maiden and the Grain

One of the most widely distributed patterns in world mythology is the story of a woman, often a girl, whose killing gives rise to the food crops on which a community lives H. Three versions bear directly on *Twin Peaks*.

The Indonesian version. The German ethnologist Adolf E. Jensen recorded it among the Wemale of Seram, in eastern Indonesia, and placed it at the center of his theory of the *dema* deity (1948). The maiden Hainuwele, born from a coconut palm, is a bearer of gifts: during a great nine-night dance she distributes precious goods to the dancers. Unsettled by her abundance, the people kill her during the dance, pressing her into a pit and burying her alive. Her father exhumes the body, cuts it into pieces, and buries them across the land. From the pieces grow the tuber plants that become the people's staple food, and her death also inaugurates human mortality.

Jonathan Z. Smith's critique of Jensen (1976) cautions against reading the myth as a universal key, and the present argument does not do so; it records an isomorphism. Laura Palmer is the community's adored girl, the homecoming queen whose portrait closes each episode of the original series. She carries meals to the town's elderly. She is killed in secret by a member of the community, and her death exposes the community's buried life.

The Native American versions. In the Cherokee story recorded by James Mooney, Selu, the Corn Mother, feeds her family with corn that she mysteriously produces from her own body. Her sons, suspecting witchcraft, kill her. Following her instructions, they drag her body around a cleared field, and corn springs up wherever her blood has fallen. In Penobscot tradition, the First Mother asks her husband to kill

her and drag her body through the land so that her flesh will become corn. In these traditions, the grain of the American continent is the body of a murdered woman. The creamed corn of the Lodge returns this mythic substance to its origin in suffering: maize as the residue of a woman's pain.

The modern American version. This one belongs to the containment era. Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery," published in *The New Yorker* in June 1948, describes a pleasant village whose citizens assemble each summer to stone one of their own, chosen by lot; this year the stones fall on a housewife. An old man justifies the custom with a rural proverb: "Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon." Jackson's village, which kills a woman each year for the sake of the corn, is the mythic substructure of Lynch's small towns, rendered in the flat prose of the postwar magazine.

The folk horror of the following decades made the structure explicit. In *The Wicker Man* (1973), an island community burns a sacrificial victim to restore its failed harvest. In Stephen King's "Children of the Corn" (1977), the children of a Nebraska town sacrifice their elders to a deity who walks behind the rows.

René Girard's theory of the founding murder explains why the pattern recurs H. In *Violence and the Sacred* (1972), Girard argued that communities in crisis discharge their accumulated violence upon a single victim, whose death restores order and who is afterward made sacred. In *Things Hidden since the Foundation of the World* (1978), he argued that the Gospels expose this mechanism by taking the victim's side.

Twin Peaks follows the second movement rather than the first. Laura's death does not restore order. The investigation into it exposes the town's hidden economy of sex, drugs, money, and violence and implicates its leading men. In Girard's terms, the series reveals things hidden.

Its audience, however, enacted the first movement. In 1990 the question "Who killed Laura Palmer?" became a national obsession, and the network pressed Lynch and Frost to answer it. Lynch later suggested that revealing the killer had killed the goose that laid the golden eggs. A nation of viewers consuming the mystery of a murdered girl's suffering is a Lodge feeding on garmonbozia. The television audience is the final term in the economy the series depicts.

4.4

Eleusis: An Ear of Grain Reaped in Silence

The Introduction proposed a constellation in which three Lynchian images converge on a single ancient sentence. This section develops it.

The Homeric *Hymn to Demeter* narrates the founding of the Mysteries at Eleusis. Hades seizes Persephone and carries her to the underworld. Her grieving mother,

Demeter, wanders the earth disguised as an old woman and comes to Eleusis, where she is hired to nurse the royal infant Demophon. Each night, in secret, she places the child in the fire to burn away his mortality. His mother discovers the practice and cries out in terror, and the goddess, revealing herself in fury, abandons the work. Demeter then withholds the grain, and the earth produces nothing. Famine threatens to extinguish humankind, and with it the sacrifices owed to the gods. Zeus relents, and Persephone is returned. Because she has eaten in the underworld, however, she must spend part of every year among the dead. Demeter restores the grain and teaches the rites of Eleusis.

The content of the rites was secret, and the very word for them preserves the secrecy. *Mystēs*, the initiate, derives from *myein*, to close the eyes or lips: the mystery is what is kept behind closed lips. Only hostile Christian writers broke the silence. Hippolytus of Rome, in his *Refutation of All Heresies* (5.8.39–40), reports the culmination of the rites. At night, amid a great fire, the hierophant displayed to the initiates "the great and marvelous and most perfect mystery," an ear of grain reaped in silence, and proclaimed that the holy Brimo had borne a holy child.

The constellation follows C. The three terms of Hippolytus's sentence are distributed across Lynch's work:

- **The ear.** *Blue Velvet* opens its descent into the underworld through a severed ear lying in a field.
- **The grain.** The Lodge consumes grain as its sacrament of pain.
- **The silence.** *Mulholland Drive* reaches its revelation in a theater called Silencio, where a woman in the balcony closes the film by commanding silence.

In each case, the term has been cut off from the others. The ear has been severed from the head and left in a vacant lot. The grain has been processed into a canned commodity and fed to demons. The silence has become a nightclub act, performed nightly for a paying audience.

The convergence depends on an English homonym: one word names both the organ of hearing and the head of grain. In a strictly philological sense, it is accidental. But Freud's *The Interpretation of Dreams* established that the dream-work proceeds precisely through such verbal bridges, condensing distinct ideas through the identity of their names. In the dream-logic that Lynch's cinema obeys, the homonym is not an accident but a mechanism.

What the constellation reveals is the state of the mystery in the containment culture. At Eleusis, the ear of grain reaped in silence was a revelation of return. The seed buried in the earth rises as harvest, the daughter taken to the dead comes back, and the initiate who has seen this no longer fears death. Lynch's America has inherited the elements of this revelation in broken form, as wound, as commodity, and as spectacle, and the bro-

ken mystery can no longer promise return. Chapter Six will argue that *The Return* attempts to perform the Eleusinian return of the daughter in a world where the rite has been dismembered, and that its ending registers what such an attempt must cost.

The myth also clarifies one of Lynch's most enigmatic figures. Sarah Palmer, Laura's mother, is the series' grieving Demeter. Her daughter has been taken into the underworld, and in *The Return* her grief has become something that blights the world around her. In a roadside bar she removes her own face to reveal a void, then tears out a man's throat with her teeth. Demeter's grief starved the earth; Sarah's has become an appetite.

Demeter's nightly practice of holding the child in the fire, interrupted by a mother's terror, is also the mythic form of the incantation that gives the first film its name. It is a fire that would make mortal things immortal, and its companionship is as dangerous as it is sacred.

4.5

The Archons' Harvest

In December 1945, five months after Trinity, an Egyptian farmer named Muhammad Ali al-Samman, digging near Nag Hammadi, unearthed a sealed jar. By his own later account, he hesitated to break it for fear that a jinn was imprisoned inside, until the hope of gold won out. The jar held the Coptic codices of the Nag Hammadi library, the most important cache of Gnostic scripture ever recovered. Within two years, Bedouin shepherds at Qumran found the first Dead Sea Scrolls, also stored in jars.

The containment era thus opened with the breaking of sealed vessels, in the physics of matter and in the archaeology of scripture alike C. The oldest Greek version of this image is Hesiod's Pandora, who opens a jar (*pithos*, not the "box" of a Renaissance mistranslation) and releases every ill into the world, leaving only hope inside. *The Return* begins with a glass box that ought never to have been opened.

The Gnostic texts recovered at Nag Hammadi describe a cosmos ruled by archons H. In the *Apocryphon of John*, Sophia, the divine Wisdom, conceives without her consort and produces a malformed being, Yaldabaoth, lion-faced and serpent-bodied. Yaldabaoth creates the archons and the material world and imprisons the divine spark in human bodies. Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) gave the twentieth century its classic account of this cosmology: an alien God, a world that is a prison, and a call from beyond to the sleeping spark. In the *Pistis Sophia*, a related text preserved in a separate codex, Sophia herself falls into chaos. The archons, led by the power called the Self-Willed, torment her in order to seize her light, and she cries out in a series of repentances until a savior raises her.

Laura Palmer's story in *Fire Walk with Me* transposes the *Pistis Sophia* into an American high school H. BOB has abused her since childhood and now wants to possess her entirely, making her body his vessel. What he wants is not only her suffering but her light. At the film's climax, in a train car in the woods, Laura puts on the ring that has come to her there, and in most readings she thereby chooses death over possession. She is killed, but her light is not taken.

The film ends in the Red Room. Laura sits with Cooper's hand on her shoulder, an angel appears, and she weeps and laughs at once. Part 8 of *The Return* later reveals that the Fireman sent her into the world. Laura is therefore not only Sophia fallen into the archons' world but the spark sent down to oppose them. Her refusal to surrender her light is the act on which the cosmology turns.

Twentieth-century esoteric literature produced its own archontologies, and their convergence with Lynch is instructive H.

- **Robert Monroe.** In *Far Journeys* (1985), Monroe, whose out-of-body explorations founded the Monroe Institute, described a cosmology in which Earth is a garden cultivated by nonhuman intelligences to harvest "loosh," an energy that living beings release in states of intense emotion.
- **Carlos Castaneda.** In *The Active Side of Infinity* (1998), Castaneda attributed to his teacher don Juan the claim that predatory beings called "flyers" had taken possession of humanity in order to feed on its awareness. His ethnography is widely regarded as fictional, but as myth it belongs to the same family.
- **Stephen King.** The purest version in horror fiction is King's *It* (1986). Its entity wakes every twenty-seven years to feed on the fear of the children of Derry, Maine, while the town's adults look away and forget.

At the end of the original series, Laura tells Cooper in the Red Room that she will see him again in twenty-five years. The series in fact returned twenty-seven years later, which happens to be King's interval.

What distinguishes Lynch within this family is that his archontology is economic and historical rather than merely metaphysical. Monroe's harvesters and Castaneda's flyers are cosmic constants, and King's entity predates the town. Lynch's Lodge, by contrast, is bound to a datable wound, Trinity, and its harvest is continuous with the real economies of the world it inhabits. The next two sections trace that continuity.

4.6

The Accursed Share

Georges Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (*La Part maudite*, 1949) proposed a "general economy." It begins from the observation that living systems receive more energy than they need to sustain themselves, ultimately from the sun. The surplus must be spent. It can be spent gloriously, in gifts, festivals, art, and eroticism, or catastrophically, in war; what cannot happen is indefinite accumulation. Bataille read Aztec sacrifice and the potlatch as institutions for the deliberate destruction of surplus. He applied the theory to his own moment as well, analyzing the Marshall Plan of 1947 as an American attempt to discharge the enormous surplus of the postwar economy D. His earlier essays in *Documents* (1929–1930), on the formless and on a "base materialism" that refuses to elevate matter into ideas, supply the aesthetic correlative noted in Chapter Two: an art of vomit, rot, and meat.

Bataille's theory explains why the Lodge's harvest concentrates in the containment era's most affluent spaces H. The postwar American suburb was the site of a surplus without historical precedent, the "affluent society" John Kenneth Galbraith named in 1958. Its official forms of expenditure (consumer goods, leisure, the arms race) did not exhaust it. Bataille's law predicts that a surplus not spent gloriously returns as catastrophe. Lynch shows where it returns: not only outward in war, but inward, upon the most vulnerable members of the household. The violence that the containment family turned on its own children is the accursed share of the affluent house.

Trinity adds a final turn. Bataille's general economy begins with the sun, whose energy is given without return. The test at Trinity produced, in the *Gītā*'s comparison, the radiance of a thousand suns: an artificial sun on earth, releasing a surplus of energy that no economy of glory could absorb. Lynch's base materialism (the vomit of *Six Men Getting Sick*, the meat of *Eraserhead*, the creamed corn of the Lodge) is the aesthetic register in which that surplus appears when it is not transfigured. Garmonbozia is the accursed share of the atomic age.

4.7

Timber and Celluloid

The economy of *Twin Peaks* is timber, and the series announces it before any character appears.

- Its opening credits linger on the machinery of a sawmill, grinding wheels sharpening saw blades in showers of sparks.

- Its first scene is set at the Packard mill, near which Pete Martell discovers Laura's body on the shore.
- Its subplots turn on the mill's ownership and on Ben Horne's scheme to destroy it for the Ghostwood resort development; the mill burns at the end of the first season.
- The Log Lady carries a piece of the forest in her arms; her husband, a woodsman, died in a fire the day after their wedding.

Blue Velvet's town is called Lumberton, and its radio station marks the hour with the sound of a falling tree. Lynch, the son of a scientist whose work concerned trees, set his two great American fables in towns built on cutting the forest down.

History here supplies a constellation that could hardly be more exact C. *Twin Peaks* premiered in April 1990. In June 1990, the United States Fish and Wildlife Service listed the northern spotted owl as a threatened species. The listing made a small owl of the old-growth forests of Washington and Oregon the emblem of the Pacific Northwest's "timber wars" between the logging economy and the preservation of the ancient forest. In those same months, one of the most talked-about dramas on American television was set in a Washington logging town whose woods were haunted by owls, and whose most famous line warned that the owls are not what they seem. The forest spirits of *Twin Peaks* are the repressed of the extractive economy: the beings who live in what the mill consumes.

Hollywood is Lynch's second extractive economy, and *Mulholland Drive* depicts it as a Lodge H. Power in the film belongs to figures who never explain themselves:

- the Castigliane brothers, one of whom tastes an espresso offered at a studio meeting and spits it into a napkin as unworthy (he is played by Angelo Badalamenti, the composer of Lynch's own music);
- a cowboy who delivers instructions on a ranch at night;
- behind them, Mr. Roque, a man with a strangely proportioned body who sits in a dim room issuing orders by telephone.

The director Adam Kesher is compelled to cast an unknown actress. The phrase that seals her selection, "This is the girl," is the formula of a sovereignty that consumes young women's ambitions. The film's final hour reveals the cost in Diane Selwyn, a failed actress ruined by the industry and by love. Her dream of herself as the radiant Betty makes up the film's first two hours.

The casting of Mr. Roque is the decisive fact D. He is played by Michael J. Anderson, who played the Man from Another Place in *Twin Peaks*, the being who, as the Arm, demands his garmonbozia in the Red Room. Lynch cast the Lodge's consumer of pain as Hollywood's hidden sovereign. Through that casting, the work's identification of the dream factory with the Black Lodge becomes explicit.

Inland Empire (2006), released with the tagline "A woman in trouble," completes the analysis. The actress Nikki Grace is cast in a film whose earlier production was abandoned after its leads were murdered. She dissolves into her character, Susan Blue, until she dies on the sidewalk of Hollywood Boulevard among homeless women, beside the stars of the Walk of Fame, and the camera pulls back to reveal a film set. Throughout, a young woman known as the Lost Girl watches the story on a hotel-room television, weeping. She is the consumer of the woman's trouble and also another woman in trouble. The industry harvests suffering on both sides of the screen.

4.8

The Woman in Trouble

No account of garmonbozia can avoid the question that has accompanied Lynch's reception since 1986: does his cinema expose the harvest of women's suffering, or participate in it? Roger Ebert's one-star review of *Blue Velvet* argued that the film subjected Isabella Rossellini to degradation. Her scenes had genuine power, he wrote, but the film's ironic and satirical framing undercut it, so that her suffering was exploited for effect. Pauline Kael, reviewing the same film, praised it as visionary. Scholarly debate followed the same lines:

- Laura Mulvey read the film as an Oedipal fable.
- Lynne Layton, in *Screen* (1994), read it as a parable of male development in which a woman's suffering serves a young man's maturation.
- Martha Nochimson argued that Lynch's women are subjects of intuitive power whose experience his films honor.

Rossellini herself has consistently defended the role.

The present argument holds that the feminist critique is correct about the structure, and that Lynch's later work is in large part a response to it H. *Blue Velvet* does stage a garmonbozia economy in which a woman's pain is the medium of a young man's initiation, and the film's camera shares Jeffrey's position in the closet. The danger Ebert identified is real: a cinema that depicts the harvest of suffering always risks becoming one more harvester. What distinguishes Lynch is that his work moves, film by film, from the position of the consumer toward the position of the consumed.

Fire Walk with Me is the turning point. Having watched a national audience consume the mystery of Laura's death, Lynch made a film about the last seven days of her life, told from her perspective, and he made it difficult to watch. He said that he was not finished with Laura and wanted to see her alive, walking and talking. The film met hostil-

ity at Cannes in 1992 and has since been reassessed as one of the most serious depictions of abuse in American cinema.

Its ethical strategy is precisely the refusal of garmonbozia. It does not turn Laura's suffering into a mystery to be solved or a spectacle to be enjoyed; it makes that suffering unbearable. In doing so, it converts the viewer's consumption into something closer to Schopenhauer's compassion: the suffering-with that sees through the veil dividing spectator from victim. *Mulholland Drive* and *Inland Empire* extend this strategy by narrating from within a woman's consciousness rather than about her.

The distinction this chapter proposes is between the woman *in* trouble and the woman *as* trouble H. Hesiod's Pandora is the founding Western image of woman as trouble: a "beautiful evil" fashioned by the gods, whose curiosity releases every ill. The femme fatale of film noir is her modern form. Lynch's films contain the femme fatale, but they expose her as a construction of male fantasy. In *Lost Highway*, the seductive Alice is what the impotent husband's jealousy makes of his wife, and at the film's climax she tells her lover that he will never have her. Lynch's women are not the source of the world's ills but their harvest. That is the difference between Pandora and Laura Palmer.

The last image of *The Return* is a woman's scream. Laura, or the woman who may have been Laura, stands before the Palmer house in a world that has forgotten her. She hears her mother's voice call her name and screams, and the lights of the house go out. Chapter Six will read this ending as a failed Grail question. Here it is enough to say what the scream is within the economy this chapter has described: pain that cannot be consumed. It is suffering that extinguishes the power of the house where it was harvested instead of feeding it. After twenty-seven years of garmonbozia, the series ends with a remainder that will not be eaten.

4.9

From Economy to Self

The garmonbozia economy requires a particular kind of subject. Its harvest is drawn from beings divided against themselves: daughters split between public radiance and secret degradation, fathers split between love and possession, actresses split between their dreams and their ruin. Laura Palmer is the homecoming queen and the girl from One-Eyed Jacks. Diane Selwyn is the radiant Betty and the ruined woman in the bathrobe. Nikki Grace is the star and the woman dying on the Boulevard. The economy of extraction runs on fission at the level of the self.

Chapter Five turns to that level. It examines the fugues, doubles, and tulpas of Lynch's late work, and reads their structure against an ancient map of consciousness.

CHAPTER FIVE

5

The Fissioned Self

FUGUES, TULPAS, AND THE FOUR STATES OF CONSCIOUSNESS

A White Lodge that could be photographed would not be the White Lodge.

§ 5.4

5.1 Splinter Psyches
5.2 The Fugue: *Lost Highway*
5.3 The Dream Economy: *Mulholland Drive*
5.4 The Four States: A Māṇḍūkya Reading
5.5 The Dreamer and the Dreamed
5.6 Tulpas: The Manufactured Self
5.7 The Sleeper Must Awaken

5.1

Splinter Psyches

The modern concept of the divided self has a clinical history that runs parallel to the literary genealogy traced in Chapter Two. That history reaches the containment era with a precision that rewards attention.

Three figures established it. In *L'Automatisme psychologique* (1889), Pierre Janet described *désagrégation*: the "disaggregation" of mental functions into systems that operate outside the subject's awareness. The English term "dissociation" descends from his work. Morton Prince's *The Dissociation of a Personality* (1906) brought the multiple personality to American readers. Jung, whose *unus mundus* Chapter One placed among the theories of the Field, also supplied one of the clearest theories of its fragmentation. Complexes, he argued, are "splinter psyches" that behave like autonomous beings. In "The Psychological Foundations of Belief in Spirits" (1920), he proposed that such complexes, projected outward, are experienced as spirits.

The most consequential artifact of this history for Lynch belongs to 1957 H C. That year Corbett Thigpen and Hervey Cleckley published *The Three Faces of Eve*, and its film adaptation won Joanne Woodward an Academy Award. Its subject is a Georgia housewife divided into two personalities. Eve White is demure and dutiful; Eve Black is a reckless, sexual pleasure-seeker. Therapy eventually produces a third, integrated woman named Jane. The containment era's most celebrated clinical case was thus a housewife split into White and Black. Thirty-three years later, Laura Palmer, homecoming queen and girl of One-Eyed Jacks, is Eve White and Eve Black again. The two Lodges between which her fate is decided bear the colors of Eve's two halves.

The clinical history also clarifies the most debated device in *Twin Peaks*: the attribution of Leland Palmer's crimes to BOB. Critics have objected that the device externalizes paternal abuse onto a demon and so exculpates the father. Jennifer Freyd's theory of betrayal trauma (1996) offers a different reading H. Freyd argues that a child abused by a caregiver on whom she depends must often split her knowledge of that caregiver. She preserves the loving parent by dissociating the abusive one.

On this reading, BOB is not an excuse for Leland. He is the form in which the father's violence appears to a daughter who cannot afford to know that it is her father. *Fire Walk with Me* dramatizes the collapse of that protective split: its central horror is Laura's discovery that the stranger who has visited her at night since childhood wears her father's face.

Lynch's cosmology then adds what it adds everywhere (Chapter Two): the splinter psyche, projected as a spirit, acquires a body of its own. BOB is both the daughter's dissociation and a being who walks.

5.2

The Fugue: *Lost Highway*

Lynch has said that while working on *Lost Highway* (1997), which he co-wrote with Barry Gifford, he came across the clinical term "psychogenic fugue" and recognized in it his protagonist's condition D. A dissociative fugue is a sudden flight from one's life, accompanied by amnesia for one's identity and, in classic cases, the assumption of a new one.

Fred Madison, a jazz saxophonist, suspects his wife Renee of infidelity. He receives a series of anonymous videotapes, each showing more of the interior of their house; the last shows Fred himself beside his wife's dismembered body. He is convicted of her murder and sentenced to death. In his cell, wracked by headaches, he disappears, and the guards find a young mechanic, Pete Dayton, in his place. Pete is released into a life of his own, including an affair with Alice Wakefield, a gangster's mistress who is Renee's double, played by the same actress.

Two scenes define the film's epistemology. In the first, detectives ask Fred whether he owns a video camera. He answers that he does not, because he likes to remember things his own way: how he remembered them, not necessarily the way they happened. The videotapes are the objective record that contradicts the fugue. They are the containment breach in documentary form, delivering to the doorstep what memory has sealed away.

In the second, a pale figure, the Mystery Man, introduces himself to Fred at a party. He claims that he is at that moment in Fred's house and invites Fred to telephone it. Fred does, and the Mystery Man's voice answers from the receiver while he stands before Fred, smiling. The agent of the fugue is a figure in two places at once: bilocation as the visible signature of fission.

The film's structure is a fugue in the musical sense as well as the clinical one C. In a contrapuntal fugue, a melody called the subject is stated and then answered by the same melody transposed to another pitch, after which the voices pursue each other through the work. Pete is Fred's answer: the same subject transposed into a younger register, potent where Fred is impotent and desired where Fred is betrayed.

The final movement brings subject and answer into collision at a burning desert cabin, filmed in reverse so that its explosion reassembles itself. It then returns Fred to his own front door, where he speaks into the intercom the sentence he heard there at the film's beginning: "Dick Laurent is dead." The fugue cannot close. Bach's *Art of Fugue* breaks off, in its surviving manuscript, in the middle of its final contrapuntal movement. *Lost Highway* likewise ends without resolution, with Fred fleeing down a night highway and convulsing toward yet another transformation.

The loop has a name in Indian thought: *saṃsāra*, the wheel of transmigration, in which the self passes from form to form without liberation. It also has a European dramatic precedent in Calderón's *La vida es sueño* (1635). The prince Segismundo, imprisoned in a tower since birth, is drugged, released to rule, returned to his cell, and told that his reign was a dream. He concludes that all of life is a dream and resolves to act well regardless.

Fred's cell is Segismundo's tower without Segismundo's conversion H. He dreams himself free and returns to the cell, but no ethical awakening follows. *Lost Highway* is Lynch's purest image of the fissioned self imprisoned in its own cycle: a wheel turning on a road at night.

5.3

The Dream Economy: *Mulholland Drive*

Mulholland Drive (2001), which began as a television pilot rejected by ABC, divides its running time between a dream and the waking life that produced it. Most scholarship has accepted Todd McGowan's account of this division as a separation of the world of fantasy from the world of desire.

For nearly two hours, the film follows Betty Elms, a radiant young actress newly arrived from Deep River, Ontario. She helps an amnesiac brunette who has survived a car accident on Mulholland Drive and taken the name Rita from a poster of Rita Hayworth in *Gilda*. Betty's audition is a triumph, and the mystery of Rita's identity draws the two women into love.

Then a blue box is opened, and in the film's final section the same actresses reappear in new roles. Naomi Watts, who played Betty, is now Diane Selwyn, a failed actress living in a squalid apartment. Laura Harring, who played Rita, is now Camilla Rhodes, Diane's successful former lover, who has left her for the director Adam Kesher. Diane hires a killer to murder Camilla and receives the blue key that signals the deed is done. Then, hallucinating, she shoots herself.

The dream is a wish-fulfillment in Freud's strict sense. Everything that failed in waking life succeeds in the dream, and the dream's distortions encode the waking materials it rearranges. Its lineage, as Chapter Two noted, is Hitchcock's *Vertigo*, in which an idealized woman turns out to be the performance of a degraded original.

Its other great precedent is Ingmar Bergman's *Persona* (1966) H. In Bergman's film, an actress, Elisabet Vogler, falls silent in the middle of a performance and is entrusted to a nurse whose identity gradually merges with hers, until their two faces are fused into a single composite image. When Betty disguises Rita in a blonde wig and the two women regard themselves together in a mirror, their faces aligned, Lynch is citing that

composite. *Persona* also anticipates Club Silencio. Its drama begins when an actress stops speaking mid-performance, and the voice that performance requires is suddenly revealed as detachable from the person who produces it.

The title of Bergman's film carries an etymology that Chapter Seven will need. The Latin *persona* means the actor's mask. In antiquity, Gavius Bassus (as reported by Aulus Gellius), and later Boethius, derived it from *personare*, "to sound through," because the actor's voice passes through the mask's opening. The etymology is doubtful philologically but exact theologically: a persona is that through which a voice sounds that is not its own. Betty, Diane's dream-self, is a persona in this sense, and so is every singer at Club Silencio.

A small detail ties the film to the rest of the corpus D C. Betty comes from Deep River, and Dorothy Vallens, in *Blue Velvet*, lives in the Deep River Apartments. Lynch's radiant dream-girl and his tormented chanteuse share an origin in a place whose name describes the Field as Lynch conceived it: a river whose depth is the source of what rises.

5.4

The Four States: A Māṇḍūkya Reading

The Introduction proposed that the architecture of Lynch's late films corresponds to the four states of consciousness analyzed in the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*. Chapter Three invoked the Upaniṣad's distinction between deep sleep and transcendence. The correspondence can now be stated in full H.

The *Māṇḍūkya* is the shortest of the principal Upaniṣads, twelve verses long. Its subject is the syllable AUM, which it declares to be all that is: past, present, and future, and whatever lies beyond the three times. It analyzes the syllable into three sounds and correlates each with a state of the self, then adds a fourth that corresponds to no sound:

- **A, the waking state (*jāgrat*).** Its self is turned outward and enjoys the gross world.
- **U, the dream state (*svapna*).** Its self is turned inward and enjoys the subtle world of mental images.
- **M, deep sleep (*suṣupti*).** There is neither desire nor dream. Its self is a unified mass of cognition, consisting of bliss. The Upaniṣad calls it the lord of all, the inner controller, and the womb from which all beings arise and into which they return.
- **The fourth (*turīya*).** It is neither inward- nor outward-cognizing, and not a mass of cognition. It is unseen, ungraspable, and indescribable: the cessation of the world,

peaceful, auspicious, and non-dual. It corresponds to no sound. It is the silence after AUM, the measureless (*amātra*) element of the syllable.

The four states map onto the four terms of the Lynchian cosmology:

- **Waking is the Containment:** the daylight world of towns, offices, and diners, outward-turned and gross.
- **Dream is the Fission:** the Red Room, the fugue, the dream of Betty, the subtle world in which selves divide and doubles walk.
- **Deep sleep is the dark Field:** undifferentiated and generative, the womb from which beings arise. It is therefore the domain of Judy, whom Chapter Three identified with Hesiod's Night, mother of Sleep and Dreams.
- **The fourth is Silencio:** the soundless element beyond the three, which Lynch's films approach only at their limits.



FIGURE 1 The Lynchian tetrad, read from the outside in: Containment (waking, A), Fission (dream, U), the dark Field (deep sleep, M), and the Field awake (the fourth state, the silence after AUM).

The distinction between the third and fourth states is the one this dissertation has been circling since its first chapter. Both are undifferentiated, but only the fourth is awake. The black void and the white luminance that recur in Lynch's work are therefore not good and evil in a moral sense. They are the two undifferentiated states of consciousness: the darkness of sleep, which is the womb of every form, and the light of transcendence, in which forms cease.

The syllable itself has a Lynchian correlate. Chapter Three described the drone beneath Lynch's soundtracks as the sound of the Emersonian current after Trinity. In the *Māṇḍūkya*'s terms, that continuous tone is AUM sounding: the hum of waking, dream, and sleep, uninterrupted beneath every scene. What it never sounds is the fourth, because the fourth is not a sound. When the hum stops, something other than sound begins.

The late films can be read as different routes through the four states:

- ***Lost Highway*** moves between waking (the Madison house) and dream (Pete's life), joined by the night highway, the darkness between them. It never reaches the fourth; it is *saṃsāra*.
- ***Mulholland Drive*** passes through all four, in a disturbed order. Its first section is dream. At Club Silencio, Betty and Rita are told that there is no band and that everything they hear is a recording. They weep as a singer collapses while her voice continues: the dream's foretaste of the fourth, sound without a sounder. The blue box then opens onto darkness, and the camera falls into it: the passage through deep sleep. What follows is waking, gross and painful. The film closes with a woman in the balcony whispering a single word, *Silencio*: the cessation of the world.
- ***Inland Empire*** dissolves the boundaries between states so completely that it is better described by Deleuze's crystal-image, his term for the point at which actual and virtual become indiscernible, than by any linear map. Uniquely in late Lynch, it ends in reunion and dance.
- ***The Return***, as Chapter Six will argue, ends in the third state rather than the fourth: in darkness, with the lights going out.

The White Lodge, finally, is never clearly shown in *Twin Peaks*. The Black Lodge is visualized elaborately, while its counterpart remains largely a rumor. In the *Māṇḍūkya*'s terms this is not an omission but a necessity, since the fourth state is by definition unseen, ungraspable, and indescribable. A White Lodge that could be photographed would not be the White Lodge.

Gauḍapāda's verse commentary on the *Māṇḍūkya*, the earliest systematic Advaita text, supplies a final image that Lynch's work completes H C. Its fourth chapter, titled the "quenching of the firebrand" (*alātaśānti*), compares the world to the patterns that appear when a burning brand is whirled in the dark. Circles, lines, and shapes seem real but are only the motion of a single fire. When the brand stops moving, the shapes vanish, and what remains is the one fire at rest.

Lynch's first film about Laura Palmer takes its title from an incantation to fire. His last image of her is a house whose lights go out. The darkness admits two readings. It may be the firebrand quenched, the forms of the dream extinguished in peace. Or it

may be the darkness of a sleep from which nothing wakes. That question is the one on which Chapter Six turns.

5.5

The Dreamer and the Dreamed

In Part 14 of *The Return*, Gordon Cole recounts a dream in which he met the actress Monica Bellucci at a Paris café. She told him that we are like the dreamer who dreams and then lives inside the dream, and then asked: "But who is the dreamer?" Lynch, who plays Cole, wrote himself into his own work as a man dreaming the oldest question in the philosophy of dreams, and that question governs the final parts of the series.

The question has a canonical lineage H.

- **Zhuangzi.** In the second chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Zhuang Zhou dreams that he is a butterfly, fluttering happily. He wakes to find himself Zhuang Zhou and cannot tell whether he is a man who dreamed he was a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming he is a man. The text calls this "the transformation of things."
- **Calderón**, as already noted, made the question the axis of a theology.
- **Lewis Carroll** gave it its most chilling form C. In *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871), Tweedledum and Tweedledee show Alice the sleeping Red King and tell her that she exists only as a thing in his dream. If he were to wake, she would go out, bang, just like a candle. The book's last chapter is titled "Which Dreamed It?" Lynch's cosmology has its own Red King, sleeping in its own red room. *The Return* ends with a woman who may be a figure in someone else's dream, and with the lights of a house going out like a candle.

Jorge Luis Borges's "The Circular Ruins" (1940) supplies the most exact precedent C. A man arrives at a ruined circular temple once dedicated to a god of fire. There he undertakes to dream a human being into existence, detail by detail, until his dreamed son is real enough to be sent into the world. The fire god promises that no one will know the son is a phantom except fire itself, which will not burn him. Years later, flames engulf the temple. The dreamer walks into the fire expecting death and finds that it does not burn him. He understands, with relief, humiliation, and terror, that he too is an appearance dreamed by another.

In Borges's story, the one who can walk with fire unharmed is thereby revealed to be dreamed. Through this constellation, the incantation that names *Fire Walk with Me* acquires a second meaning: it is the formula of the dreamed being. Such a creature's immunity to fire proves that it is not real in the way it believed.

Laura, sent from the Fireman's tower as an orb, is such a being. So is Dougie Jones, and so is the woman Cooper finds in Odessa at the end. The question Cooper asks there, "What year is this?", is the question of a dreamed man who has begun to suspect that the fire will not burn him.

5.6

Tulpas: The Manufactured Self

The Return names its manufactured beings with a Tibetan term, *tulpa*. The word reached Western occultism chiefly through the French explorer Alexandra David-Néel D. In *Magic and Mystery in Tibet* (1929; English 1931–1932), she reported that she had created a tulpa herself through sustained concentration: a short, fat, jolly monk. The monk gradually became visible, acquired a life of its own, and grew sly and malignant. Eventually others could see him, and dissolving him took her six months. The Tibetan word behind the term, *sprul pa*, means emanation or magical apparition. It belongs to the same family as *sprul sku* (*tulku*), the Tibetan rendering of *nirmāṇakāya*: the emanation-body in which a realized being appears in the world out of compassion.

Lynch's tulpas invert the Buddhist doctrine H. In Tibetan Buddhism, awakened beings produce emanations for the benefit of others. In *The Return*, Mr. C, the malign double, produces them as decoys and instruments.

- **Dougie Jones** is manufactured so that he, rather than Mr. C, will be drawn back into the Lodge when Cooper is released. In the Red Room, MIKE tells him that someone manufactured him for a purpose and that the purpose is fulfilled. Dougie collapses into a small golden seed amid smoke.
- **Diane Evans**, Cooper's confidante, is likewise revealed as a tulpa. Her manufactured double, exposed and shot, appears in the Red Room, declares that she is not herself, and in turn collapses into a golden seed. The real Diane has been imprisoned elsewhere as Naido, an eyeless woman in a void, and emerges only near the end.

David-Néel's report is precise about the danger: the made being escapes its maker's control and turns sly and malignant. Mr. C's tulpas are the made beings of a maker who was himself made by fission. The Blue Rose of Chapter Three, the impossible double that does not occur in nature, is the FBI's name for them. Their oldest Western ancestor is Hesiod's Pandora, the first woman, manufactured by the gods as a beautiful evil.

Yet the series also contains a tulpa made in love, and its making is among the most tender acts in all of *Twin Peaks* H C. As the restored Cooper prepares to leave Las

Vegas, he asks MIKE to make another Dougie for Janey-E and Sonny Jim, the wife and son who have come to love the emptied man. MIKE asks for a seed, and Cooper plucks a hair from his own head. The new Dougie arrives at their door. In Mr. C's hands the manufactured self is an instrument of evasion; in Cooper's it becomes a gift that repairs a family.

Here the golden seed into which tulpas collapse rejoins the argument of Chapter Four. The Lodge eats the seed corn, whereas the tulpa's seed, given a hair of the original, is planted. The same substance serves the economy of extraction and the economy of compassion, depending on who holds it.

5.7

The Sleeper Must Awaken

The fissioned self in Lynch has a goal, and it was announced, unexpectedly, in his most compromised film. *Dune* (1984), adapted from Frank Herbert's novel, is a story of awakening. Its recurrent incantation, "The sleeper must awaken," is the Gnostic call that Hans Jonas identified as the central motif of the Gnostic religion: a voice from beyond, summoning the spark that has fallen asleep in the world H.

The hero becomes the Kwisatz Haderach. The novel glosses the name as the "shortening of the way," and Lynch's film describes him as the one who can be many places at once. His multiplicity is not fission but omnipresence: the One appearing in many places without dividing. Lynch also added to Herbert's material a technology of his own invention, the "weirding modules," devices that convert sound into physical force D. In the film's universe, as in the physics of consciousness of Chapter One, sound is power.

The film's production supplies a coda that belongs in any account of the fissioned self D. Lynch disowned the extended version later assembled for television. Its credits name the director as "Alan Smithee," the standard pseudonym of disowned films, and the screenwriter as "Judas Booth," a name compounded from history's archetypal betrayer and the assassin of Lincoln. The author split himself in two: the Lynch who made *Dune*, and the double who bears responsibility for its mutilation.

The Return fulfills *Dune*'s incantation in its own idiom. For fifteen parts the sleeper does not awaken. Reduced to Dougie, Cooper moves through Las Vegas as a holy fool, repeating words and devouring pie. Through acts he does not understand, he rescues an insurance firm and reconciles gangsters. Then, in Part 15, he hears the name Gordon Cole spoken in *Sunset Boulevard*, crawls to a socket with a fork, and receives the current that wakes him. In Part 16 he opens his eyes in a hospital bed, fully himself, and an-

nounces that he is the FBI. The three Coopers are reduced to one: the tulpa returns to a seed, the double is destroyed, and the original is restored.

But restoration is not liberation. The reintegrated Cooper immediately undertakes the series' most ambitious act: to travel back in time and prevent the murder of Laura Palmer. He seeks, in other words, to repair the original fission by narrative intervention. Chapter Six follows him into that attempt and reads it through the oldest Western stories of a hero who descends to bring someone back.

CHAPTER SIX

6

The Grail Question

ORPHEUS, PERCEVAL, AND THE FAILURE OF RETROACTIVE REDEMPTION

The Grail quest fails because it is a quest.

§ 6.7

6.1 The Wasteland
6.2 The Grail and the Question
6.3 The Pure Fool: Parsifal and Dougie
6.4 Orpheus and the Phantom
6.5 The Return of the Daughter: Eleusis Without the Rite
6.6 Rollback: The Angel of History
6.7 "What Year Is This?"



6.1

The Wasteland

Twin Peaks: The Return is set in a wasteland, and it takes pains to show it. Its fathers and elders are dead, dying, or damaged:

- Sheriff Harry Truman, the good patriarch of the original series, never appears. He is said to be gravely ill, and his brother serves in his place.
- Major Briggs, the series' wisest father, is dead. His headless body is discovered in South Dakota beneath a murdered librarian's head, and his own head floats enormous in a void, speaking two words: "Blue Rose."
- The Log Lady, the town's oracle, telephones Deputy Hawk from her deathbed to say that she is dying, and then dies.
- Gordon Cole, the Bureau's paternal chief, is nearly deaf.

Beyond the town, the country lies in ruins of a specifically contemporary kind. In the half-empty, foreclosed subdivision of Rancho Rosa in Las Vegas, a mother screams a number from her porch while her small son watches. In Twin Peaks, a young woman is consumed by addiction. At the Roadhouse, young women in booths trade fragments of stories about abuse and disappearance while bands play on the stage behind them. The suburban paradise of the containment era, now foreclosed, narcotized, and abandoned, is the landscape into which the sleeper wakes.

The figure of the Waste Land comes from the Grail romances. It reached modern literature through Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920), which argued that the Grail legend preserved the outlines of ancient fertility rites in which the health of the land depends on the health of its king D. That king is the Fisher King: wounded and impotent, unable either to rule or to die, he passes his days fishing while his land lies sterile. T. S. Eliot acknowledged in his notes that Weston's book suggested the plan of *The Waste Land* (1922), and he placed the Fisher King at the poem's end: "I sat upon the shore / Fishing, with the arid plain behind me."

The image completes a constellation begun in this dissertation's first chapter C. Lynch theorized the artist as a fisherman, and the Fisher King of the romances is a fisherman whose wound lays waste the land. *The Return* is the work of a fisherman in old age, sitting on the shore of his own fiction with its arid plain behind him. Many of its actors were already dead. Frank Silva and Don S. Davis died before production; David Bowie, Catherine Coulson, Miguel Ferrer, and Warren Frost before broadcast; Harry Dean Stanton within two weeks of the finale. The series is a memorial as well as a quest.

6.2

The Grail and the Question

The decisive episode of the Grail legend is a failure to speak. In Chrétien de Troyes's unfinished *Perceval, or the Story of the Grail* (c. 1180s), the young knight Perceval, a naïf raised in the forest, arrives at the castle of the wounded Fisher King. There he witnesses a procession: a lance whose tip bleeds, a grail borne by a maiden and blazing with light, and a silver carving dish. He wishes to ask what these things mean and whom the grail serves. But his tutor has advised him not to talk too much, so he remains silent. In the morning the castle is empty. A cousin tells him that had he asked, the king would have been healed and the land restored; because he did not, the misery continues.

Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (c. 1200–1210) gives the failure its ethical form H. The question Parzival must ask, and at first fails to ask, concerns not the Grail but the king: "Uncle, what ails you?" The question is valid only if it is spontaneous, arising from compassion rather than from curiosity or instruction. Wolfram's hermit Trevrizent insists that the Grail cannot be won by striving; it comes only to the one who is called. The king's wound, in Wolfram, is in the genitals, inflicted by a poisoned spear when Anfortas pursued a love forbidden to the Grail king. The sexual wound of the father lays waste the realm.

The Grail structure runs throughout *Twin Peaks* H. The entrance to the Black Lodge is Glastonbury Grove, named for the English town that monks identified with Avalon in 1191, when they announced the discovery of Arthur's grave. Later legend made Glastonbury the place where Joseph of Arimathea brought the Grail. Lynch's Glastonbury is a ring of twelve sycamores around a pool of black oil, announced by the smell of scorched engine oil. It is the Grail chapel of an industrial wasteland.

The sycamore extends the constellation C. In ancient Egypt the sycamore fig was sacred to Hathor and Nut, the "Lady of the Sycamore." Tomb paintings show this tree-goddess at the edge of the necropolis, pouring water and offering food to the dead. The trees that ring the Lodge's entrance are the trees that stood at the threshold of the Egyptian underworld.

The town's wounded king is plural. Leland Palmer embodies the father's sexual wound that lays the land waste. Ben Horne, in the second season, collapses into a regressive delusion. In *The Return*, the good king, Harry Truman, lies sick and unseen. The Grail castle's vessel also has its Lynchian forms. The Double R's "damn fine" coffee is the cup of communion in which the town's daily sacrament is poured. Its antitype is the cup offered to Cooper in the Red Room at the end of the second season, which congeals into sludge: the anti-Grail, a vessel whose contents cannot be drunk.

Dale Cooper is Perceval, and the question of which Perceval he is governs the whole saga. He is a knight of method. He throws Tibetan stones and records tape dispatches to Diane in which every observation, every meal, and every price enters the record. In the original series, his method is subordinated to intuition and dream. In *The Return*, once awakened, he becomes something else.

6.3

The Pure Fool: Parsifal and Dougie

Chapter One promised that Schopenhauer's ethics of compassion would return through Wagner's *Parsifal* (1882). Wagner had read Schopenhauer in 1854 and built his last opera around Schopenhauerian *Mitleid* D. The Grail knights await a redeemer foretold by a single line: *durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor*, "made wise through compassion, the pure fool."

Parsifal enters as a fool indeed. He shoots a sacred swan without understanding what he has done. He witnesses the agony of the wounded king Amfortas at the Grail ceremony and understands nothing, and he is driven out as a simpleton. Only in the second act, when the enchantress Kundry kisses him, does he suddenly feel the king's wound as his own and cry out, "Amfortas! The wound!" Compassion arrives not through reasoning but through an experience that dissolves the boundary between his body and the sufferer's. He returns on Good Friday with the holy spear and heals the king, following a principle the opera's final scene states outright: only the spear that struck the wound can close it.

That principle is ancient. When Telephus was wounded by Achilles' spear, an oracle declared that the one who wounded would heal, and scrapings from the same spear cured him. Lynch's cosmology obeys the principle exactly H. Chapter Three showed that the same electrical current that carries BOB between bodies wakes Cooper from his exile. The current that split the self is the current that reunites it: Cooper is healed by the spear that wounded him, a fork in a wall socket.

Dougie Jones is Lynch's Parsifal before his awakening. His sojourn in Las Vegas is the most extended portrait of the pure fool in American television H. He understands nothing. He repeats the last words spoken to him, follows lights that appear above slot machines, and wins jackpot after jackpot. He points a woman who has been losing all afternoon toward a winning machine. At Lucky 7 Insurance, a corrupt colleague, Anthony Sinclair, tries to poison his coffee. Dougie, without apparent intention, begins to knead an ache in Anthony's shoulder, and Anthony breaks down in tears and confesses. Gangsters sent to kill him end by bringing him gifts. A wife who had despaired of her husband finds herself loved, and a son whose father was a stranger gains one.

Dougie heals without asking. He does not pose the Grail question because he never poses any question at all. His compassion is pure gesture: a hand on an aching shoulder.

This is the paradox on which the chapter turns. The pure fool, who knows nothing and seeks nothing, heals everyone he touches. The restored hero, who knows everything and seeks the greatest good imaginable, fails. Wolfram's hermit had warned that the Grail cannot be won by striving. Dougie was called; Cooper, once awakened, strives.

6.4

Orpheus and the Phantom

When Cooper wakes, he resolves to save Laura Palmer by going back in time to the night of her death. The structure of his attempt is Orphic. The Orphic tradition offers three versions of the hero who descends to bring someone back, and each illuminates a different aspect of his failure.

Ovid: the backward look. The canonical version is Ovid's (*Metamorphoses* X), following Virgil's in the fourth *Georgic*. After his wife Eurydice dies, Orpheus descends to the underworld and moves its rulers with his song. They grant her return on condition that he not look back at her until they reach the upper air. Near the threshold he turns, from fear or longing, and she slips back into death with a farewell he can scarcely hear.

In Part 17 of *The Return*, Cooper enters the night of 23 February 1989 and finds Laura in the woods, on her way to the death the series has spent twenty-seven years recounting. He takes her by the hand and leads her through the dark trees, away from her fate. Then she is gone: her hand is no longer in his, and a scream echoes through the forest. Re-edited footage from the 1990 pilot shows the consequence D. Pete Martell sets out to go fishing, and the shore where he once found Laura's body wrapped in plastic is empty. The fisherman casts his line on a morning without a corpse.

Plato: the phantom. The second version is Plato's, and it is the more devastating HC. In the *Symposium* (179d), Phaedrus says that the gods never gave Orpheus his wife at all. They showed him only a phantom (*phasma*) of her, because he seemed soft: a lyre-player who would not dare to die for love, unlike Alcestis, who died in her husband's place.

In Part 18, Cooper finds in Odessa, Texas, a waitress named Carrie Page who has Laura's face and no memory of Laura's life, and he drives her through the night to Twin Peaks. Chapter Five read the tulpa as a manufactured double; Plato supplies its Orphic form. Carrie Page is the *phasma* given to an Orpheus who did not die for love. In the economy of this saga, the one who did die for love is Laura herself, who in *Fire Walk*

with Me chose death over possession. Laura is Alcestis. Cooper is the Orpheus to whom the gods gave a phantom.

Cocteau: the reversal. The third version is Cocteau's, introduced in Chapter Two H. In *Orphée* (1950), Orpheus is forbidden ever to look at Eurydice again. He loses her when he glances into a car's rearview mirror and sees her in the back seat. Cocteau's film then ends with a reversal Lynch does not grant. The Princess, Death herself, loves Orpheus. She breaks the laws of her realm to reverse time, returning Orpheus and Eurydice to their life before any of the events occurred, with no memory of them, and is then led away to an unknown punishment. Retroactive redemption succeeds in Cocteau, but only because Death sacrifices herself.

In *The Return*, during the night drive to Twin Peaks, headlights appear behind the car, and Carrie grows uneasy as Cooper watches the mirror. No one sacrifices herself to reverse time. Cooper attempts the reversal on his own authority, and it fails.

One final Orphic image belongs to the next chapter. After his second loss, Orpheus was torn apart by the Maenads, and his severed head, Ovid writes, floated down the river still singing. The voice that continues after the body has been destroyed is the subject of Club Silencio.

6.5

The Return of the Daughter: Eleusis Without the Rite

Chapter Four argued that *The Return* attempts the Eleusinian return of the daughter in a world where the rite has been dismembered. The final hour bears this out H C.

In the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter*, Persephone's return is not a heroic rescue but the outcome of a cosmic negotiation. Demeter's grief starves the earth, Zeus relents, and Hermes, guide of souls, is sent down to bring the daughter back to her mother. Even then the return is partial and cyclical: because Persephone has eaten in the underworld, she must go back there every year. The rite at Eleusis does not deny her captivity. It folds that captivity into the order of the seasons, the grain that dies and rises.

Cooper casts himself as Hermes, the agent who brings the daughter home. He brings Carrie Page to the Palmer house, but Demeter is not there. The door is opened by a stranger named Alice Tremond, who says she bought the house from a Mrs. Chalfont. Tremond and Chalfont are the two names borne by the Lodge's grandmother, the figure whose masked grandson once held the creamed corn. The mother's house now belongs to the Lodge. Persephone has been fetched from Judy's coffee shop, a place named for the extreme negative force, and returned to a house owned by the Lodge's own. Bewildered, Cooper steps back into the street.

Then the mother's voice is heard, faint and disembodied, calling "Laura" from somewhere in the house. Demeter is now a voice without a body: the acousmatic mother. The daughter hears her own name and screams. The Eleusinian *anodos*, the daughter's ascent to her mother, ends at the threshold. The mother is present only as sound, and the daughter recognizes herself only as terror.

In mythic terms, Cooper's error is plain. He has tried to return Persephone outside the order that makes her return possible: not through the mother's grief, the consent of the gods, and the cycle of the grain, but through one man's intervention in time.

6.6

Rollback: The Angel of History

Walter Benjamin's "On the Concept of History" (1940), written months before his death, clarifies the ethical core of the failure H. Its ninth thesis describes Paul Klee's painting *Angelus Novus*, which Benjamin owned, as the angel of history. His face is turned toward the past. Where we perceive a chain of events, he sees one single catastrophe that keeps piling wreckage at his feet. He would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed. But a storm blowing from Paradise catches his wings and drives him irresistibly into the future, while the pile of debris grows skyward. The storm, Benjamin says, is what we call progress.

In Part 17, Cooper is the angel who tries to stay. He goes back to awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed, and the storm carries him into a future he does not recognize. Benjamin's theses also distinguish two conceptions of redemption, and that distinction separates *Fire Walk with Me* from *The Return*:

- **Historicism**, which Benjamin rejects, conceives time as homogeneous and empty: a line along which events are arranged and could, in principle, be rearranged.
- **Messianic redemption** does not correct the past causally. It is a "weak messianic power" given to every generation, a secret agreement with those who came before, by which the past is redeemed in a "now-time" that interrupts the line. Every second, Benjamin writes in an appendix, is the strait gate through which the Messiah might enter.

Fire Walk with Me enacts messianic redemption H. In her bedroom Laura keeps a framed picture of an angel tending children at a table, and as her despair deepens, the angel vanishes from the picture. In the train car, the other captive girl, Ronette Pulaski, sees an angel, and her bonds loosen. Laura's angel does not prevent her death. It appears afterward, in the Red Room, where Laura sits with Cooper's hand on her shoulder, sees the angel above her, and weeps and laughs at once.

The redemption occurs within the catastrophe, not by undoing it. Cooper's role in 1992 is that of the compassionate witness, standing beside her with his hand on her shoulder. That gesture is the Grail question rightly posed, without words: what ails you? I am here.

The Return enacts historicism. The awakened Cooper treats time as a line he can travel and alter, and his intervention is sovereign rather than compassionate. The containment era supplies a name for this posture C. In the early 1950s, opposed to Kennan's containment, stood "rollback": the doctrine, associated with James Burnham and John Foster Dulles, that America should not merely contain Soviet power but actively reverse what had already occurred. Rollback foundered in Hungary in 1956, the year in which Part 8 sets its creature crawling into the girl's mouth. Cooper's project in Part 17 is rollback applied to time itself.

Retroaction, the attempt to reach back and alter what has occurred, is the structure whose failure Chapter Three anticipated in the retroactive dedication of Penderecki's *Threnody*. In *The Return*, its failure follows a precise logic. A world in which Laura was never murdered is a world in which she was never found, never mourned, and never investigated: a world in which the town never came to know her. Cooper does not save Laura; he erases her. The shore is empty, the house belongs to strangers, and the woman with her face does not know her name. The price of undoing the death is undoing the person, and that undoing is itself a new fission, the last and deepest of the series.

6.7
"What Year Is This?"

Standing in the street before the house, Cooper asks the question with which the saga ends: "What year is this?"

It is the wrong question, and the Grail tradition shows why H. Perceval should have asked whom the Grail serves; Parzival, what ails the king. Both questions are addressed to another's suffering. Cooper's is a detective's question, addressed to the chronology: the last datum missing from the record. It asks about time rather than about the one who suffers in it.

Chapter Three showed what Time is in the verse Oppenheimer recited: *kāla*, the destroyer of worlds. Cooper's final question is addressed to the god who appeared at Trinity. Augustine observed that he knew what time was as long as no one asked him, and could not say once he was asked. The Lynchian cosmos answers Cooper's question with a scream.

Eliot's *The Waste Land* supplies the question Cooper did not ask C. The poem ends with thunder, and its thunder comes from the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* (5.2). There the creator's thunder speaks the syllable DA three times, and each class of his offspring hears a different command:

- the gods hear *dāmyata*: control yourselves;
- humans hear *datta*: give;
- the demons, the asuras, hear *dayadhvam*: be compassionate.

Eliot sets the three words in his final section and closes with the Upaniṣadic benediction, *Shantih shantih shantih*, the peace that passes understanding. The command of compassion is addressed to the demons, and Lynch's cosmology contains one demon who heard it. MIKE, by his own account, saw the face of God, was changed, and cut off the arm that bore the tattoo of his former partnership with BOB. In the language of the thunder, the Grail question is *dayadhvam*. Cooper asks for the date.

The darkness that follows the scream admits the three readings Chapter Five prepared, and the series holds all three open:

- **Carroll's reading:** the Red King has woken, and the dreamed girl has gone out like a candle.
- **Gauḍapāda's reading:** the firebrand has stopped whirling, and the forms of the dream are quenched in peace, *śānti*, Eliot's last word.
- **The containment reading:** the house's power has failed. The grid that hummed in its walls goes dead at the instant the unconsumable remainder is voiced.

The series does not choose among them, but its credits add a final image. Over them plays the scene from the first Red Room dream in which Laura leans toward Cooper and whispers in his ear, and we do not hear what she says. The secret passes into the ear and is never spoken aloud. In the vocabulary of Eleusis, it remains a mystery in the root sense: kept behind closed lips.

The Grail quest fails because it is a quest. In its place, the saga's own logic proposes not a better intervention but a different relation to time and to suffering: the hand on the shoulder rather than the hand that leads away, the witness rather than the rescuer, a slowness that does not seek to reverse anything. Lynch made a film about that relation, and it is the most unexpected work in his canon. It concerns an old man who rides a lawnmower across two states to sit beside his estranged brother and look at the stars.

CHAPTER SEVEN

7

The Straight Path

SILENCE, SLOWNESS, AND THE SOTERIOLOGY OF THE FIELD

The refusal to explain is the refusal to replace an experience with a lesson.

§ 7.7

7.1 The Counter-Tradition
7.2 *The Grandmother*: Love from a Seed
7.3 *The Elephant Man*: Nothing Will Die
7.4 *The Straight Story*: Duration
7.5 The Puppet and the God
7.6 The Depths: Lovecraft and Machen
7.7 Silencio: The Unstruck Sound
7.8 Terminal Luminance
7.9 The Weather Report

7.1

The Counter-Tradition

The preceding chapters have reconstructed a cosmology of fission:

- a Field split at Trinity;
- a containment culture that stores the split's energy;
- an economy that harvests suffering;
- a self divided into fugues and tulpas;
- a hero whose attempt to undo the original wound produces a deeper one.

A reader who stopped there would conclude that Lynch is the poet of the wound. But the work also contains a counter-tradition, running from a student film of 1970 to the last weather report: a set of works and scenes in which the split is not repaired by force but dissolved by gentleness. Its principles are those the Grail chapter derived from the failure of Cooper's quest: compassion rather than intervention, witness rather than rescue, slowness rather than rollback.

This chapter reconstructs that counter-tradition and sets it against three alternatives from modern horror: Lovecraft's cosmic indifference, Machen's violent unveiling, and Ligotti's pessimism. It finds the tradition's culmination in the sourceless voice of Club Silencio.

The organizing distinction can be stated at once H. There are two ways to lift the veil. One is violent: the surgeon's knife, the physicist's bomb, the detective's forced entry into time. The other is effortless: the mind settling toward its own source without strain, as in Maharishi's analogy. Lynch's horror films depict the first way; his counter-tradition depicts the second. The difference between them is the whole of his ethics.

7.2

The Grandmother: Love from a Seed

The counter-tradition begins with *The Grandmother* (1970), an early short Lynch made with an American Film Institute grant. Grotesque, animalistic parents bark at and beat their son. In the attic the boy finds a bag of seeds. He plants one in a mound of soil heaped on a bed and tends it, and it grows into a grandmother who comforts him with a tenderness his parents never showed. She sickens and dies, and he is alone again.

The film anticipates the structures of the late work with a precision its maker could not have planned H C. An abused child who cannot escape the household grows, from a seed, a being made of love: a tulpa of compassion, nearly fifty years before *The Return*. Two later moments repeat the boy's gardening:

- When MIKE, at Cooper's request, makes a new Dougie for Janey-E and Sonny Jim from a golden seed and a hair (Chapter Five).
- When, in the cosmology of Part 8, the Fireman forms Laura Palmer as a golden orb of light and sends her into the world to be planted in a house of abuse.

In the economy of Chapter Four, the Lodge eats the seed corn. In the counter-tradition, the seed is planted, and what grows from it is a protector.

7.3

The Elephant Man: Nothing Will Die

The Elephant Man (1980) is the counter-tradition's first full statement. Chapter Two read it as a study of the body under the gaze, exhibited first in the freak show and then in the hospital. Its ending answers the question Merrick shouts in the railway station: is he an animal or a human being?

In the last sequence, Merrick completes his model of St. Philip's Church H. Only the spire is visible from his window, so he has built the rest from imagination. He signs the model and looks at a picture on his wall of a child asleep in bed. The weight of his head would suffocate him if he lay flat, so he has always slept sitting up. Now he removes his pillows and lies down like the sleeping child, knowing what it will mean.

The camera then leaves the room and moves into a field of stars. His mother's face appears and speaks lines from Tennyson's early poem "Nothing Will Die" (1830): "Never, oh! never, nothing will die; / The stream flows, / The wind blows, / The cloud fleets, / The heart beats, / Nothing will die." The image dissolves into light.

The answer to Merrick's question is neither "animal" nor "human" but something the question did not contemplate H. He is a river entering the sea, in the image of the *Chāndogya Upaniṣad* (Chapter One), giving up name and form without ceasing to be. His model church, completed from a visible spire and an imagined whole, is an emblem of the Field: the unseen completed by inner vision. His death is not the extinction Lovecraft's cosmos would assign it but a return to the stars, where his mother's voice speaks of continuance.

It is also a chosen death, as Laura's was. Merrick's decision to lie down, like her decision to put on the ring, is the act by which a person refuses to remain the property of a regime that exhibits or possesses him. Like *Fire Walk with Me*, the film ends in light and places redemption inside death rather than in its prevention.

7.4

The Straight Story: Duration

The Straight Story (1999) is the most anomalous film in Lynch's canon, and for that reason the most important to this argument D H. It was written by John Roach and Mary Sweeney and released by Disney with a G rating. It dramatizes the true story of Alvin Straight, a seventy-three-year-old Iowan who could not drive and refused to be driven. In 1994 he rode a 1966 John Deere lawn tractor some 240 miles to Mount Zion, Wisconsin, to see his brother Lyle, who had suffered a stroke and with whom he had not spoken in ten years. Richard Farnsworth, who played Alvin, was terminally ill during filming and died the year after the film's release.

Every element of the cosmology of fission appears in the film, transfigured H C.

- **The lawnmower.** It is the instrument of the suburban lawn, the tool that keeps the containment surface in order. In *Blue Velvet* the camera descended beneath such a lawn into the beetles' war. Here the lawnmower becomes a pilgrim's vehicle, riding not under the lawn but across the Midwest, at walking pace, in daylight.
- **The highway.** In *Lost Highway* it is a night road of fission. In *The Straight Story* it is a shoulder lane through harvest country, filmed from above as combines move through golden fields.
- **The grain.** In the Lodge it is consumed as suffering (Chapter Four). Here it is reaped by communal labor in its proper season.

The film's encounters replay the themes of the preceding chapters in a reconciling key:

- A pregnant runaway shares Alvin's campfire, and he tells her that a single stick breaks but a bundle does not.
- A woman who keeps hitting deer with her car on her commute weeps over the latest carcass. Alvin roasts the venison and mounts the antlers on his trailer, so the animal is honored rather than wasted.
- Bickering twin mechanics, a pair of comic doubles, repair his tractor and argue over the price.
- In a bar, Alvin confesses to another veteran that as a sniper in the Second World War he shot a scout from his own unit by mistake, something he has never told anyone. The war, the century's great fission, is not undone; it is confessed.
- His daughter Rose, whose children were taken from her after a fire, lives with the loss without bitterness.

At the end, Alvin arrives at Lyle's cabin. Lyle, leaning on a walker, asks whether he rode that machine all that way to see him, and Alvin says he did. They sit on the porch

and look at the stars, as they did when they were boys.

The film's form is its argument. Henri Bergson distinguished the spatialized time of clocks from *durée*, lived duration. In *Creative Evolution* (1907) he offered an image of it: if I want to make a glass of sugar-water, I must wait until the sugar melts. The image echoes, across two and a half millennia, Uddālaka's salt in the *Chāndogya Upaniṣad*, dissolved in water, invisible, yet tasted everywhere C.

Alvin Straight's journey is the time it takes for the sugar to melt. It cannot be accelerated, because its meaning is its duration. It cannot be reversed, because what it repairs is not the past but the present relation between two old men. Cooper asks what year it is; Alvin never asks.

The Straight Story is the one Lynch film in which a split is healed. It is healed by the opposite of every method the Grail chapter found wanting: by slowness, by confession rather than retroaction, and by the simple act of arriving and sitting beside someone.

7.5

The Puppet and the God

Chapter Six turned on a paradox: the pure fool heals, while the knowing hero fails. Heinrich von Kleist's essay "On the Marionette Theater" (1810) formulates that paradox precisely H. Kleist's interlocutor, a dancer, argues that the marionette has a grace no human dancer can achieve, because it has no self-consciousness to distort its movement; its soul lies at its center of gravity. Grace, he concludes, appears most purely in a form that has either no consciousness at all or an infinite one: in the puppet, or in the god. The self-conscious, divided human lies between the two. Paradise is locked behind us, and to regain it we must travel around the world and eat again of the tree of knowledge.

Dougie Jones is Kleist's marionette. His grace is the puppet's: he is moved by strings he cannot see, and everything he touches is healed. The awakened Cooper is the self-conscious human between puppet and god, and his grace fails. Kleist's solution is that the way back to innocence lies not behind consciousness but through it, toward infinity. That is also the Vedantic solution, and it is Lynch's. Meditation does not abolish consciousness; it deepens consciousness until it becomes, in the *Māṇḍūkya*'s terms, the fourth state.

Thomas Ligotti resolves the same image in the opposite direction. He draws on Schopenhauer and on Peter Wessel Zapffe's "The Last Messiah" (1933), both in stories such as those collected in *Songs of a Dead Dreamer* (1986) and in his treatise *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010). Ligotti treats human beings as puppets who

have become aware that they are puppets, and finds only horror in that awareness. For him, consciousness is a tragic accident, and existence is better ended than continued.

Ligotti is Schopenhauer without the Upaniṣads: the Black Lodge mistaken for the whole cosmos H. Lynch shares his imagery of the puppet, the mechanical body, and the dreamer, but not his valuation. In Lynch the strings are real. When they are held from the White Lodge rather than the Black, the puppet's movements are grace.

7.6

The Depths: Lovecraft and Machen

No comparison clarifies Lynch's position more sharply than H. P. Lovecraft H. Lovecraft's essay "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1927) opens by declaring fear the oldest and strongest human emotion, and fear of the unknown its oldest and strongest kind. "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) opens with his most famous claim: the most merciful thing in the world is the mind's inability to correlate all its contents. We live on "a placid island of ignorance in the midst of black seas of infinity," Lovecraft writes, and were not meant to voyage far. Beneath those seas, in the sunken city of R'lyeh, "dead Cthulhu waits dreaming."

Lynch and Lovecraft share an image and invert its value. Both picture reality as an ocean whose depths lie beneath the island of ordinary life.

- **For Lovecraft**, the ocean is black, indifferent, and maddening. The deeper one goes, the worse it is, and the merciful course is containment.
- **For Lynch**, following Maharishi, the ocean is consciousness. The deeper one goes, the larger and more beautiful the fish.

Horror in Lynch belongs to the middle depths: the dream state and its fissions, the Red Room, the fugue. At the bottom is bliss. Lovecraft's dreaming god sleeps beneath the sea and will wake to annihilate. Lynch's cosmos contains such a figure in Judy, Night, the dark pole, but contains her within a Field whose ground is light. Lovecraft is the philosopher of containment, and he endorses it. Lynch is the artist of containment who breaches it and finds peace beneath the horror.

Arthur Machen's *The Great God Pan* (1894) supplies a comparison that concerns method rather than cosmology H. Dr. Raymond, a physician who believes the material world is a veil, operates on the brain of Mary, a young woman he regards as his to use, so that she can see what lies beyond it. The ancients, he says, called this seeing the god Pan. Mary sees and is destroyed. She becomes an idiot and dies after giving birth to a daughter, Helen Vaughan, who brings ruin and suicide to the men she encounters.

Machen's tale is the founding modern fable of forced revelation, and its structure is the structure of Part 8 (Chapter Three): an experiment that tears the veil of matter by violence and engenders a monstrous offspring. Late antiquity read the Greek name Pan as "All," so the vision Raymond forces is a vision of the All. Lynch agrees with Machen that the All can be seen, and that seeing it by violence produces monsters. He differs in holding that there is another way: not surgery but transcending, not the knife but the settling of the mind. Trinity is Raymond's operation performed on matter. Transcendental Meditation, as Lynch understood it, is the same unveiling performed with no knife at all.

7.7

Silencio: The Unstruck Sound

Three threads from earlier chapters converge at Club Silencio H C. Chapter One argued that Lynch's curtain conceals both the One and the speaker. Chapter Five argued that a persona is that through which a voice sounds. Chapter Six recalled that Orpheus's severed head went on singing.

At two in the morning, Betty and Rita enter a theater in downtown Los Angeles. A master of ceremonies announces in Spanish, English, and French that there is no band: everything they hear is a recording. A trumpeter lowers his instrument from his lips, and the trumpet goes on playing. The master of ceremonies raises his arms; thunder sounds, blue light flares, and he vanishes in smoke while Betty shakes uncontrollably in her seat. Then Rebekah Del Rio comes to the microphone and sings, unaccompanied, a Spanish version of Roy Orbison's "Crying." Midway through she collapses on the stage, and her voice continues without her. The two women weep. Afterward Betty finds the blue box in her purse.

The scene is a theory of the voice, and Michel Chion's acousmatics lets it be stated exactly. Chion's *acousmêtre* (1982) is a voice whose source is unseen. Such a voice, he argued, has quasi-divine powers (ubiquity, omniscience, omnipotence), which are lost the moment its source is revealed, a process he called de-acousmatization. His paradigm cases both involve curtains:

- In Fritz Lang's *The Testament of Dr. Mabuse* (1933), a commanding voice behind a curtain turns out to be a loudspeaker placed before a cardboard silhouette.
- In *The Wizard of Oz* (1939), Toto pulls back a curtain to reveal a little man at a microphone.

In both, revelation disenchants. Club Silencio reverses the structure. The voice is first attached to a visible body, the singer, and then detached from her: the body collapses

and the voice persists. What is revealed is not that the voice belonged to a mere person but that it never belonged to a person at all. The voice is re-acousmatized, returned to sourcelessness, and its power grows. The women do not laugh at the trick; they weep.

The curtain and the recording carry Chapter One's Indian genealogy to its conclusion, on three counts.

- **"It is all recorded."** The Mīmāṃsā philosophers who held the Vedas to be authorless (*apauruṣeya*) also held that sound itself is eternal: the reciter does not produce the Veda but manifests it. The nightclub host speaks a Mīmāṃsā doctrine. The performer lip-syncs to an eternal sound that precedes her and survives her collapse.
- **"No hay banda."** The master of ceremonies' repeated negation is *neti neti*: not this, not this.
- **The voice without a sounder.** Yogic tradition has a name for it. The fourth chapter of the *Haṭha Yoga Pradīpikā* is devoted to attending to *nāda*, the inner sound. The tradition distinguishes *āhata nāda*, sound produced by striking, from *anāhata nāda*, the unstruck sound heard in meditation, which has no physical cause and gives the heart center its name. The poems of Kabir, which Rabindranath Tagore rendered into English in 1915, speak of "the unstruck music." The trumpet that plays when no one blows it, the song that continues after the singer has fallen, is the unstruck sound.

Silencio thus stages the full sequence of the *Māṇḍūkya* (Chapter Five):

1. **The struck sound:** trumpet, voice, applause, the hum of the three states.
2. **The unstruck sound:** the voice continuing after its apparent source has failed.
3. **Silence:** the word the woman in the balcony speaks at the film's end, the measureless element after AUM.

What the women undergo is not instruction but initiation. Aristotle, in a fragment preserved by Synesius, wrote that those initiated into the Mysteries are not meant to learn anything, but to experience something and be brought into a certain state. Betty and Rita learn nothing at Club Silencio. They weep, and are changed. That is the pedagogy of the whole oeuvre: the refusal to explain is the refusal to replace an experience with a lesson.

7.8

Terminal Luminance

The soteriology can be read in the endings of Lynch's films, which fall into two families H.

THE LUMINOUS ENDINGS FOLLOW ACCEPTANCE, COMPASSION, OR SURRENDER:

- *Eraserhead* ends in a white radiance in which the Lady in the Radiator embraces Henry.
- *The Elephant Man* ends among the stars, with a mother's voice saying that nothing will die.
- *Dune* ends with rain falling on the desert planet, a miracle Lynch added to Herbert's story. The wasteland that Eliot's poem waits on is given water.
- *Wild at Heart* ends when the Good Witch, played by Sheryl Lee, appears in a bubble and tells Sailor not to turn away from love, and he runs across the roofs of stalled cars to sing to Lula.
- *Fire Walk with Me* ends with the angel.
- *The Straight Story* ends with the stars.
- *Mulholland Drive* ends in the word for silence.
- *Inland Empire* ends with the Lost Girl reunited with her husband and son in a burst of light, and then with women dancing.

THE DARK ENDINGS FOLLOW POSSESSION OR RETROACTION:

- *Lost Highway* ends with Fred on the night highway, convulsing into another self.
- The second season of *Twin Peaks* ends with BOB's face in Cooper's mirror.
- *The Return* ends with the scream and the lights going out.

Blue Velvet belongs to neither family exactly. Its sunlit ending, with a robin on the windowsill holding a beetle in its beak, is luminous. But the robin is visibly mechanical, and the luminance is the containment surface restored rather than the Field attained.

The pattern confirms the argument of the preceding chapters. Where Lynch's characters seek to seize, possess, or reverse, the film ends in darkness. Where they accept, witness, or love, it ends in light.

7.9

The Weather Report

In the last years of his life, Lynch broadcast brief daily weather reports from his Los Angeles studio. He sat at a desk and looked out at the morning. He reported the sky

and the temperature, often in terms of blue skies and golden sunshine, drew a number from a jar, announced it, and wished his viewers a great day.

The reports were received as a charming eccentricity, but they belong to the soteriology this chapter has traced HC. They are acts of attention to the ordinary sky, repeated daily without spectacle: Robert Henri's art life reduced to its essence. The state of being in which, for Henri, the work becomes inevitable has itself become the work.

Over the same years, the David Lynch Foundation, established in 2005, funded instruction in Transcendental Meditation for schoolchildren, veterans, and survivors of violence. The efficacy claims made for such programs remain debated, but their intention is the practical form of *Fire Walk with Me*'s angel, offered to the living.

The counter-tradition is not an exception to the cosmology of fission but its answer. The Field split at Trinity is not repaired by reversing Trinity, as Cooper tried to reverse Laura's death. It is approached gently and from within, through attention: a boy tending a seed, a dying man lying down beneath the stars, an old man on a lawnmower, a voice that sounds when no one is singing, a filmmaker describing the weather. The Conclusion formalizes the system these chapters have assembled.

CONCLUSION



The Fissile Sublime

The work he left is the record of what rose.

§ C.5

C.1 The System

C.2 The Fissile Sublime: A Formalization

C.3 Nocturnal Transcendentalism Beyond Lynch

C.4 Limits and Objections

C.5 Coda: The Ear of the Ear

C.1

The System

This dissertation set out to show that the work of David Lynch, read across six decades and every medium in which he worked, constitutes a single cosmology. The argument has run through seven chapters. Its results can now be gathered into a system of four terms, which correspond, as Chapter Five showed, to the four states of consciousness in the *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*:

- **Containment (waking).** This is the daylight world of postwar America: suburbs, small towns, diners, offices, sitcoms, the dream factory. Its function is to store the energy of a split while concealing that the split exists. Its excessive brightness is the visible cost of that labor (Introduction, Chapters Three and Four).
- **Fission (dream).** This is the splitting of the One: historically at Trinity, psychologically in the doppelgänger and the fugue, domestically in the daughter divided within the father's house. Its products are doubles and an energy, garmonbozia, on which parasitic beings feed (Chapters Two through Five).
- **The dark Field (deep sleep).** This is the undifferentiated ground as the womb of all forms, unconscious and generative. Its figures are Night, Judy, and the black void into which the camera falls (Chapters Three and Five).
- **The Field awake (the fourth).** This is the undifferentiated ground as consciousness: the white luminance of the endings, the angel, the unstruck voice, silence. It cannot be shown, only approached, and it is reached not by intervention but by attention (Chapters One, Six, and Seven).

Each of the five propositions advanced in the Introduction has been sustained:

1. Reality in Lynch is grounded in a unified field of consciousness. Lynch accepted from the Transcendental Meditation movement the identification of that field with the unified field of physics. That identification turns physical events, such as the splitting of the atom and the flow of current, into metaphysical events.
2. Evil is the parasitic yield of fission: an appetite born at a datable moment and nourished on suffering.
3. Postwar normality is a containment structure.
4. The characteristic Lynchian affect is the perception of unity at the instant of its rupture.
5. Lynch's soteriology is non-narrative. Cooper tries to undo the original wound by traveling back in time and only deepens it. The gestures of the counter-tradition dissolve it instead: the hand on the shoulder, the slow journey, the voice that sounds without a singer.

The system also accomplishes the integration the Introduction proposed. The psychoanalytic readings of Lynch (Mulvey, Žižek, McGowan) describe the Fission with precision. The spiritualist and Gnostic readings (Nochimson, Wilson) describe the Field. The historicist readings (Jameson, Nieland) describe the Containment. Chapter One supplied the figure that unites them: the torus, Lynch's doughnut, whose hole is not opposed to its substance but constitutive of its form. The critics who see the hole and the critics who see the dough are describing one surface.

C.2

The Fissile Sublime: A Formalization

The concept this dissertation has called the fissile sublime can now be defined formally. It names an experience with five conditions:

1. **A totality otherwise unpresentable becomes perceptible.** This totality is the unified field, the One.
2. **It becomes perceptible only through its division**, at the instant and by the fact of its splitting, just as matter revealed its energy only in being split.
3. **The perceiving subject is situated inside a containment structure** that both shields and implicates it: the suburb, the house, and above all the screen.
4. **The resulting affect oscillates between dread and comedy**, because division produces doubles. The double is at once the harbinger of death (Rank) and the mechanical encrusted on the living (Bergson).
5. **The experience admits no resolution through comprehension or action**, only through relaxing the will to comprehend and to act.

Each condition distinguishes the fissile sublime from a predecessor:

- **Burke's** sublime requires a safe distance. The third condition abolishes that distance, because the containment that shields the subject is also what has stored the catastrophe.
- **Kant's** sublime resolves in reason's triumph over the failure of imagination. The fifth condition forbids that resolution.
- **Otto's** numinous is the presence of a wholly other. Under the second condition, the totality appears not as other but as one's own world split open.
- **Jean-François Lyotard's** postmodern sublime, the presentation of the fact that the unpresentable exists (1982), names the first condition but not the second.
- **David Nye's** *American Technological Sublime* (1994) counts the atomic test among the great spectacles of technological power. It describes the same events Lynch de-

picts, but from the side of the spectator who celebrates them; the fissile sublime perceives in those spectacles the rupture of the Field.

- **Jameson's** "hysterical sublime" of late capitalism, the euphoria of a totality too vast to map, is the fissile sublime without its metaphysics.
- **Žižek's** ridiculous sublime is its comic face, explained by the fourth condition.

The third condition deserves emphasis, because it locates the fissile sublime in a medium. Its paradigmatic subject is the viewer before the glass. There is Sam, watching the box in the first hour of *The Return*; the television audience of 1990, consuming the mystery of Laura Palmer's death; and the Lost Girl in her hotel room, weeping before a screen. The fissile sublime is the sublime proper to an age in which the screen is the containment wall. This is why Lynch, a painter who wanted his paintings to move and sound, became a filmmaker and then a maker of television. The screen is the place where containment and its breach can be staged at once.

C . 3

Nocturnal Transcendentalism Beyond Lynch

Nocturnal Transcendentalism, the name this dissertation has given Lynch's position, can be proposed as a category with purchase beyond his work. A work belongs to it when it meets four criteria:

1. It posits a non-dual ground beneath appearances.
2. It locates the disclosure of that ground in a historically specific wound.
3. It treats ordinary life as a containment surface.
4. It seeks redemption not in narrative victory but in attention, stillness, or compassion.

Several works suggest the category's range. They are offered as directions for further study, not as claims of influence.

Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) is the clearest instance H. Its Zone, produced by an unexplained catastrophe, contains a Room said to grant one's innermost wish. A professor carries a small nuclear bomb into the Zone to destroy the Room before it can be misused. At the threshold he chooses not to detonate it, dismantles the device, and scatters its parts in the water. *Stalker* is an anti-Trinity: the scientist brings fission to the sacred place and refrains. Its pilgrims travel slowly, like Alvin Straight, and, unlike Cooper, they refuse the wish-fulfilling intervention at the threshold.

The name of Tarkovsky's territory has a history of its own C. Cocteau's underworld in *Orphée* is "the Zone." So is the occupied Germany of Thomas Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973), a novel of the V-2 rocket and the dissolving self. Seven years after

Stalker, the territory around the ruined reactor at Chernobyl, entombed in a concrete sarcophagus, came to be called the Zone by those who entered it. The Zone is the containment era's name for the land where the Field shows through the split.

Other works extend the category in different directions:

- **Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981)** is Gnostic revelation in a Californian key: a beam of pink light discloses that the world is a prison whose empire never ended.
- **Don DeLillo's *Underworld* (1997)** opens on the October afternoon in 1951 when a pennant-winning home run coincided with news of a Soviet atomic test. It contains a scene that could stand beside *Fire Walk with Me*: the face of a murdered girl from the Bronx appears on a billboard whenever a passing train's lights strike it, and crowds gather as for a miracle.
- **Apichatpong Weerasethakul's *Cemetery of Splendour* (2015)** concerns soldiers sunk in an inexplicable sleep in a hospital built over an ancient royal burial ground. The dead kings, the film suggests, are drawing on the sleepers' energy to fight their own battles: garmonbozia in a Theravāda register.
- **The television series *Severance* (2022–)** shows a corporation surgically dividing its employees' consciousness into a working self and a home self: the fission of the self rendered as labor policy.

Each of these works meets some of the criteria and departs from others. The category is useful precisely because it makes those departures legible.

C.4

Limits and Objections

Five limits of this study should be acknowledged.

> **First, the method risks the error it most resembles.** Klaus Conrad coined the term "apophenia" (1958) for the perception of meaningful connection among unrelated things. Umberto Eco, in *Interpretation and Overinterpretation* (1992), warned against a hermeneutics that finds everywhere the secret it seeks. Dale Cooper, throwing stones at a bottle, figures this temptation, and a dissertation that reads Lynch through rhymes risks becoming Lynchian in the wrong sense. Grading every claim as documented genealogy, structural homology, or constellational disclosure was designed as a safeguard. The reader is entitled to reject any constellation whose yield seems insufficient, and the argument's structure does not depend on any single one.

> **Second, the science is contested.** Much of the cosmology rests on identifying the unified field of physics with consciousness, an identification mainstream physics

does not accept. The social claims made for group meditation also remain contested. This study has treated these ideas as the imaginative premises of Lynch's work, not as established truths.

Third, the use of Indian sources follows a long Western pattern. From Schopenhauer and Emerson to the commercialization of meditation in the twentieth century, Western thinkers have drawn on South Asian thought as a metaphysical resource. Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978) remains the necessary caution. Advaita Vedānta is one school within a living and internally contested tradition that also includes the qualified non-dualism of Rāmānuja and the dualism of Madhva. The readings offered here concern only the strands of that tradition that reached Lynch, chiefly through Maharishi Mahesh Yogi.

Fourth, "Lynch's cosmology" is a convenient shorthand for collaborative work. *Twin Peaks* was created with Mark Frost, whose interest in Theosophy and American history shaped its mythology. *Lost Highway* was written with Barry Gifford, and *The Straight Story* was written by John Roach and Mary Sweeney. The sound of the work belongs as much to Alan Splet, Angelo Badalamenti, and Dean Hurley as to its director. In this respect, Lynch's own theory of the idea as caught rather than authored is more accurate than auteurist criticism.

Fifth, the feminist question raised in Chapter Four remains open. This study has argued that Lynch's work moves from the position of the consumer of women's suffering toward the position of the consumed. Whether any depiction of such suffering can fully escape the economy it depicts is a question the work itself poses and does not answer.

C . 5

Coda: The Ear of the Ear

This dissertation began with a camera entering a severed ear lying in the grass. It ends with a whisper into an ear. Over the end credits of *The Return*, Laura Palmer leans toward Dale Cooper in the Red Room and whispers something we do not hear.

The *Kena Upaniṣad*, read in Chapter One, describes the ground of all things as the ear of the ear: not anything that is heard, but that by which hearing happens, which no ear can hear. Read through that verse, Laura's whisper is not a withheld message. It is a secret only in the Eleusinian sense: kept behind closed lips because it cannot be spoken, and passed directly into the organ that receives it.

Lynch's work is an extended circuit between these two ears. At one end is the ear found in a vacant lot, through which the camera descends into the underworld of a

containment culture. At the other is the ear into which the murdered girl, sent from the Fireman's tower, speaks what cannot be said.

David Lynch died in January 2025, at the age of seventy-eight, leaving the work complete and its question open. He described the artist as a fisherman: one who waits at the edge of dark water for something larger than himself to rise. The work he left is the record of what rose.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Works Cited

WORKS BY DAVID LYNCH

Films and television. *Six Men Getting Sick* (*Six Times*) (1967); *The Alphabet* (1968); *The Grandmother* (1970); *Eraserhead* (1977); *The Elephant Man* (1980); *Dune* (1984); *Blue Velvet* (1986); *Twin Peaks*, created with Mark Frost (ABC, 1990–1991); *Wild at Heart* (1990); *Twin Peaks: Fire Walk with Me* (1992); *Lost Highway* (1997); *The Straight Story* (1999); *Mulholland Drive* (2001); *Rabbits* (2002); *Inland Empire* (2006); *Twin Peaks: The Missing Pieces* (2014); *Twin Peaks: The Return*, created with Mark Frost (Showtime, 2017).

Writings and companion texts.

Frost, Mark. *The Secret History of Twin Peaks*. New York: Flatiron Books, 2016.

———. *Twin Peaks: The Final Dossier*. New York: Flatiron Books, 2017.

Lynch, David. *Catching the Big Fish: Meditation, Consciousness, and Creativity*. New York: Tarcher/Penguin, 2006.

Lynch, David, and Kristine McKenna. *Room to Dream*. New York: Random House, 2018.

Rodley, Chris, ed. *Lynch on Lynch*. London: Faber and Faber, 1997; rev. ed. 2005.

SCHOLARSHIP AND CRITICISM ON LYNCH

Chion, Michel. *David Lynch*. Trans. Robert Julian. London: BFI, 1995. First published Paris: Cahiers du cinéma, 1992.

Ebert, Roger. Review of *Blue Velvet*. *Chicago Sun-Times*, 19 September 1986.

Fisher, Mark. *The Weird and the Eerie*. London: Repeater, 2016.

Jameson, Fredric. *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1991.

Kael, Pauline. "Out There and In Here." *The New Yorker*, 22 September 1986.

Layton, Lynne. "*Blue Velvet*: A Parable of Male Development." *Screen* 35, no. 4 (1994).

Lim, Dennis. *David Lynch: The Man from Another Place*. Boston: New Harvest, 2015.

Mactaggart, Allister. *The Film Paintings of David Lynch: Challenging Film Theory*. Bristol: Intellect, 2010.

McGowan, Todd. *The Impossible David Lynch*. New York: Columbia University Press, 2007.

Mulvey, Laura. "Netherworlds and the Unconscious: Oedipus and *Blue Velvet*." In *Fetishism and Curiosity*. London: BFI, 1996.

Nieland, Justus. *David Lynch*. Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 2012.

Nochimson, Martha P. *The Passion of David Lynch: Wild at Heart in Hollywood*. Austin: University of Texas Press, 1997.

———. *David Lynch Swerves: Uncertainty from Lost Highway to Inland Empire*. Austin: University of Texas Press, 2013.

Wallace, David Foster. "David Lynch Keeps His Head." *Premiere*, September 1996. Repr. in *A Supposedly Fun Thing I'll Never Do Again*. Boston: Little, Brown, 1997.

Wilson, Eric G. *The Strange World of David Lynch: Transcendental Irony from Eraserhead to Mulholland Dr.* New York: Continuum, 2007.

Žižek, Slavoj. *The Art of the Ridiculous Sublime: On David Lynch's Lost Highway*. Seattle: Walter Chapin Simpson Center for the Humanities, University of Washington, 2000.

INDIAN AND EAST ASIAN SOURCES

Anquetil-Duperron, Abraham Hyacinthe, trans. *Oupnek'hat*. 2 vols. Strasbourg, 1801–1802.

The Bhagavad-Gita: Krishna's Counsel in Time of War. Trans. Barbara Stoler Miller. New York: Bantam, 1986.

Bhāgavata Purāṇa; *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa*.

David-Néel, Alexandra. *Mystiques et magiciens du Thibet*. Paris: Plon, 1929. Eng. trans. *Magic and Mystery in Tibet*, 1932.

The Early Upaniṣads: Annotated Text and Translation. Trans. Patrick Olivelle. New York: Oxford University Press, 1998. (Bṛhadāraṇyaka, Chāndogya, Taittirīya, Kena, Muṇḍaka, Māṇḍūkya.)

Gauḍapāda. *Māṇḍūkya Kārikā*.

Hagelin, John S. "Is Consciousness the Unified Field? A Field Theorist's Perspective." *Modern Science and Vedic Science* 1, no. 1 (1987): 29–87.

Kabir. *Songs of Kabir*. Trans. Rabindranath Tagore. New York: Macmillan, 1915.

Maharishi Mahesh Yogi. *Science of Being and Art of Living*. London: International SRM Publications, 1963.

Śaṅkara. *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya*.

Svātmārāma. *Haṭha Yoga Pradīpikā*.

Vivekananda, Swami. Letter of February 1896. In *The Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda*. Mayavati: Advaita Ashrama.

Windisch, Ernst. "Der griechische Einfluss im indischen Drama." Berlin, 1882.

Zhuangzi, chap. 2, "Qiwulun."

CLASSICAL, BIBLICAL, AND MEDIEVAL SOURCES

Aristotle. Fragment 15 (Rose), preserved in Synesius, *Dio*.

Augustine. *Confessions*, book XI.

Aulus Gellius. *Attic Nights* 5.7.

Boethius. *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium*.

Chrétien de Troyes. *Perceval, ou le Conte du Graal*. c. 1180s.

Donne, John. "Holy Sonnet XIV" ("Batter my heart"). In *Poems*. London, 1633.

Heraclitus. Fragments B30, B64 (Diels–Kranz).

Hesiod. *Theogony*; *Works and Days*.

Hippolytus of Rome. *Refutation of All Heresies* 5.8.39–40.

The Holy Bible, King James Version. John 12:24.

Homeric Hymn to Demeter.

Ovid. *Metamorphoses*, books X–XI.

Pistis Sophia. Ed. Carl Schmidt. Trans. Violet MacDermot. Leiden: Brill, 1978.

Plato. *Symposium*.

Pseudo-Dionysius. *Mystical Theology*.

Robinson, James M., ed. *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*. San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1977. (*Apocryphon of John*.)

Virgil. *Georgics*, book IV.

Wolfram von Eschenbach. *Parzival*. c. 1200–1210.

PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOANALYSIS, RELIGION, AND THEORY

Bataille, Georges. "Informe." *Documents* 1, no. 7 (1929).

———. *La Part maudite*. Paris: Minuit, 1949.

Benjamin, Walter. *Ursprung des deutschen Trauerspiels*. Berlin: Rowohlt, 1928.

———. "Über den Begriff der Geschichte." 1940.

Benjamin, Walter, and Gershom Scholem. *The Correspondence of Walter Benjamin and Gershom Scholem, 1932–1940*. Ed. Gershom Scholem. Trans. Gary Smith and Andre Lefevere. New York: Schocken, 1989.

Bergson, Henri. *Le Rire*. Paris: Alcan, 1900.

———. *L'Évolution créatrice*. Paris: Alcan, 1907.

Burke, Edmund. *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful*. London: Dodsley, 1757.

Chion, Michel. *La Voix au cinéma*. Paris: Cahiers du cinéma, 1982.

Conrad, Klaus. *Die beginnende Schizophrenie*. Stuttgart: Thieme, 1958.

Deleuze, Gilles. *Francis Bacon: Logique de la sensation*. Paris: La Différence, 1981.

———. *Cinéma 2: L'Image-temps*. Paris: Minuit, 1985.

Eco, Umberto, et al. *Interpretation and Overinterpretation*. Ed. Stefan Collini. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992.

Foucault, Michel. *Naissance de la clinique*. Paris: PUF, 1963.

Freud, Sigmund. *Die Traumdeutung*. Leipzig and Vienna: Deuticke, 1900 [1899].

———. "Das Unheimliche." *Imago* 5 (1919).

———. "Die Ichspaltung im Abwehrvorgang." Written 1938; published 1940.

Freyd, Jennifer J. *Betrayal Trauma: The Logic of Forgetting Childhood Abuse*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996.

Girard, René. *La Violence et le sacré*. Paris: Grasset, 1972.

———. *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde*. Paris: Grasset, 1978.

Heidegger, Martin. *Sein und Zeit*. Halle: Niemeyer, 1927.

Janet, Pierre. *L'Automatisme psychologique*. Paris: Alcan, 1889.

Jensen, Adolf E. *Das religiöse Weltbild einer frühen Kultur*. Stuttgart: Schröder, 1948.

Jentsch, Ernst. "Zur Psychologie des Unheimlichen." *Psychiatrisch-Neurologische Wochenschrift* 8 (1906).

Jonas, Hans. *The Gnostic Religion*. Boston: Beacon, 1958.

Jung, C. G. "The Psychological Foundations of Belief in Spirits." 1920.

———. "A Review of the Complex Theory." 1934.

———. *Mysterium Coniunctionis*. Zürich: Rascher, 1955–1956.

Jung, C. G., and Wolfgang Pauli. *Naturerklärung und Psyche*. Zürich: Rascher, 1952.

Kant, Immanuel. *Kritik der Urteilskraft*. Berlin: Lagarde und Friederich, 1790.

Kleist, Heinrich von. "Über das Marionettentheater." *Berliner Abendblätter*, December 1810.

Lacan, Jacques. "Le stade du miroir comme formateur de la fonction du Je." 1949. In *Écrits*. Paris: Seuil, 1966.

———. *Le Séminaire, Livre IX: L'identification*. 1961–1962.

Lyotard, Jean-François. "Answering the Question: What Is Postmodernism?" In *The Postmodern Condition*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1984.

Mooney, James. *Myths of the Cherokee*. Washington, DC: Government Printing Office, 1900.

Nye, David E. *American Technological Sublime*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1994.

Otto, Rudolf. *Das Heilige*. Breslau: Trewendt & Granier, 1917.

Prince, Morton. *The Dissociation of a Personality*. New York: Longmans, Green, 1906.

Rank, Otto. *Der Doppelgänger*. Leipzig: Internationaler Psychoanalytischer Verlag, 1925. First published in *Imago* 3 (1914).

Said, Edward W. *Orientalism*. New York: Pantheon, 1978.

Schaeffer, Pierre. *Traité des objets musicaux*. Paris: Seuil, 1966.

Schopenhauer, Arthur. *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung*. Leipzig: Brockhaus, 1819.

Smith, Jonathan Z. "A Pearl of Great Price and a Cargo of Yams." *History of Religions* 16, no. 1 (1976).

Weston, Jessie L. *From Ritual to Romance*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1920.

Wimsatt, W. K., and Monroe C. Beardsley. "The Intentional Fallacy." *Sewanee Review* 54 (1946).

Zapffe, Peter Wessel. "Den sidste Messias." *Janus* 9 (1933).

ESOTERIC SOURCES

Blavatsky, H. P. *The Secret Doctrine*. London: Theosophical Publishing Company, 1888.

Castaneda, Carlos. *The Active Side of Infinity*. New York: HarperCollins, 1998.

Deren, Maya. *Divine Horsemen: The Living Gods of Haiti*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1953.

Fortune, Dion. *Psychic Self-Defence*. London: Rider, 1930.

Monroe, Robert A. *Far Journeys*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1985.

LITERATURE

Borges, Jorge Luis. "Las ruinas circulares." 1940. In *Ficciones*. Buenos Aires: Sur, 1944.

Calderón de la Barca, Pedro. *La vida es sueño*. 1635.

Carroll, Lewis. *Through the Looking-Glass, and What Alice Found There*. London: Macmillan, 1871.

DeLillo, Don. *Underworld*. New York: Scribner, 1997.

Dick, Philip K. *VALIS*. New York: Bantam, 1981.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *The Double*. 1846.

Eliot, T. S. *The Waste Land*. New York: Boni and Liveright, 1922.

Emerson, Ralph Waldo. *Nature*. Boston: James Munroe, 1836.

———. "The Over-Soul." In *Essays: First Series*. Boston: James Munroe, 1841.

———. "Brahma." *Atlantic Monthly*, November 1857.

Gogol, Nikolai. "The Nose." 1836.

Hawthorne, Nathaniel. "Young Goodman Brown." 1835.

Henri, Robert. *The Art Spirit*. Comp. Margery Ryerson. Philadelphia: Lippincott, 1923.

Herbert, Frank. *Dune*. Philadelphia: Chilton, 1965.

Hoffmann, E. T. A. *Die Elixiere des Teufels*. Berlin: Duncker und Humblot, 1815–1816.

———. "Der Sandmann." In *Nachtstücke*. Berlin, 1816.

Jackson, Shirley. "The Lottery." *The New Yorker*, 26 June 1948.

Kafka, Franz. *Die Verwandlung*. Leipzig: Kurt Wolff, 1915.

———. "Vor dem Gesetz." 1915.

———. *In der Strafkolonie*. Leipzig: Kurt Wolff, 1919.

———. "Die Sorge des Hausvaters." In *Ein Landarzt*. Munich: Kurt Wolff, 1920.

King, Stephen. "Children of the Corn." 1977.

———. *It*. New York: Viking, 1986.

Ligotti, Thomas. *Songs of a Dead Dreamer*. Albuquerque: Silver Scarab, 1986.

———. *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race*. New York: Hippocampus, 2010.

Lovecraft, H. P. "Supernatural Horror in Literature." *The Recluse*, 1927.

———. "The Call of Cthulhu." *Weird Tales*, February 1928.

Machen, Arthur. *The Great God Pan*. London: John Lane, 1894.

Poe, Edgar Allan. "William Wilson." 1839.

Pynchon, Thomas. *Gravity's Rainbow*. New York: Viking, 1973.

Stevenson, Robert Louis. *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*. London: Longmans, Green, 1886.

Tennyson, Alfred. "Nothing Will Die." In *Poems, Chiefly Lyrical*. London: Effingham Wilson, 1830.

Thoreau, Henry David. *Walden; or, Life in the Woods*. Boston: Ticknor and Fields, 1854.

Whitman, Walt. *Leaves of Grass*. Brooklyn, 1855.

———. "Passage to India." 1871.

HISTORY, POLITICS, AND CULTURE

Burnham, James. *Containment or Liberation?* New York: John Day, 1953.

Galbraith, John Kenneth. *The Affluent Society*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1958.

Jungk, Robert. *Heller als tausend Sonnen*. Bern: Scherz & Goverts, 1956. Eng. trans. *Brighter than a Thousand Suns*, 1958.

Kennan, George F. ("X"). "The Sources of Soviet Conduct." *Foreign Affairs* 25, no. 4 (July 1947).

May, Elaine Tyler. *Homeward Bound: American Families in the Cold War Era*. New York: Basic Books, 1988.

Thigpen, Corbett H., and Hervey M. Cleckley. *The Three Faces of Eve*. New York: McGraw-Hill, 1957.

OTHER FILMS AND MUSIC CITED

Films. Apichatpong Weerasethakul, *Cemetery of Splendour* (2015); Ingmar Bergman, *Persona* (1966); Luis Buñuel, *The Exterminating Angel* (1962) and *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie* (1972); Luis Buñuel and Salvador Dalí, *Un Chien Andalou* (1929); Jean Cocteau, *The Blood of a Poet* (1930) and *Orphée* (1950); David Cronenberg, *Videodrome* (1983); Maya Deren and Alexander Hammid, *Meshes of the Afternoon* (1943); Victor Fleming, *The Wizard of Oz* (1939); Robin Hardy, *The Wicker Man* (1973); Alfred Hitchcock, *Vertigo* (1958); Nunnally Johnson, *The Three Faces of Eve* (1957); Fritz Lang, *The Testament of Dr. Mabuse* (1933); Hideo Nakata, *Ringu* (1998); Christopher Nolan, *The Prestige* (2006); Stellan Rye, *The Student of Prague* (1913); Andrei Tarkovsky, *Stalker* (1979); Charles Vidor, *Gilda* (1946); Billy Wilder, *Sunset Boulevard* (1950); *Severance*, created by Dan Erickson (Apple TV+, 2022–).

Music. J. S. Bach, *Die Kunst der Fuge* (published 1751); Krzysztof Penderecki, *Threnody to the Victims of Hiroshima* (1960); Richard Wagner, *Parsifal* (1882).

INDEX OF TERMS

Keywords

David Lynch · *Twin Peaks* · Nocturnal Transcendentalism · fissile sublime · containment culture · Cold War domesticity · atomic age · Trinity test · unified field · Transcendental Meditation · Advaita Vedānta · *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* · American Transcendentalism · the uncanny · doppelgänger · dissociation · psychogenic fugue · tulpa · Gnosticism · garmonbozia · political economy of affect · Eleusinian Mysteries · Grail legend · Fisher King · Orpheus · messianic time · acousmatic sound · *anāhata nāda* · feminist film theory · psychoanalytic film theory · time-image · American Gothic · cosmic horror · folk horror · comparative mythology · film-philosophy

SET IN TEX GYRE PAGELLA AND TEX GYRE ADVENTOR

